

United Nations Security Council

Study Guide



**Agenda : Reforming the UNSC, Emphasizing Membership
Expansion and Restricting Veto Power**

Global School of Science Model United Nations



Reforming the UNSC: Emphasizing Membership Expansion and Restricting Veto Power

1. Introduction to the Committee



The United Nations Security Council Chamber in New York, where critical decisions on international peace and security are made.

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the UN's six principal organs and holds **primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security** [1]. Unlike the General Assembly, the Council can impose **binding obligations** on all UN member states [2] [3]. It can authorize peacekeeping missions, impose sanctions, and even approve the use of military force in response to threats or breaches of peace [4]. The UNSC's decisions (resolutions) are legally binding, meaning UN members are obligated to carry them out under the UN Charter [5]. This authority makes the Council a powerful body but also one whose legitimacy rests on its representativeness and effectiveness.

Composition: The Council has **15 member states: 5 permanent members** (the P5 the United States, Russia, China, France, and the United Kingdom) and **10 non-permanent members** elected for two-year terms [6]. The P5 were the major World War II victors and hold a special privilege: **each permanent member can veto any substantive Council decision** [7]. Non-permanent members, by contrast, have no veto and are elected on a regional basis (five from various regions are elected each year) [6] [8]. A Council resolution on substantive matters requires at least **9 votes in favor and no veto from any P5** (procedural matters only need 9 votes and cannot be vetoed) [9] [10]. This voting rule, rooted in Article 27 of the UN Charter, grants each P5 member what is effectively a “**veto**” power over Council decisions [9] [11].

Mandate and powers: Under the UN Charter, the Security Council's mandate is to **prevent and respond to threats to peace**. It may investigate disputes, demand ceasefires, dispatch peacekeeping forces, impose economic sanctions, or authorize collective military action [12] [13]. All UN members “agree to accept and carry out” the Council's decisions, giving those decisions a binding force unique within the UN system [5]. The Council's design reflects a post-WWII order in which great-power unanimity was seen as essential to avoid the organization's paralysis or collapse (as happened with the League of Nations). Indeed, the P5's veto was intended to ensure they would cooperate and not be forced to accept action against their vital interests [14]. *Supporters of the veto argue* that the UN would not survive if binding decisions could

be made against a major power; they view the veto as a safeguard that keeps powerful states engaged in the UN and prevents unilateral domination [14]. *Critics*, however, call the veto “the most undemocratic element” of the UN, noting it often paralyzes action in the face of war crimes or crises involving a P5 or its allies [15]. This tension between great-power privilege and democratic representation underpins many debates about UNSC reform.

MUN simulation: In Model UN settings, the Security Council is a popular and challenging committee. **You assume the roles of the 15 Council member states**, including the P5 with veto power. They must negotiate under real UNSC rules for example, any *substantive* draft resolution needs nine affirmative votes **and no P5 veto** to pass. This means a delegate representing a P5 country can (in simulation) exercise a “veto” by voting no on a draft resolution, instantly blocking its adoption. You representing elected members have no veto and thus often focus on building coalitions and achieving the requisite nine votes. The **procedural rules** in a MUN Security Council are slightly more flexible than larger assemblies for instance, there is usually **no General Speakers’ List**; the Council can move directly into caucusing and resolution-drafting given its small size. Voting, however, follows the real 15-member format. The **President of the Council** (often the committee chair in MUN) sets the agenda and moderates debate. Importantly, because of the veto, consensus-building is crucial: a single P5 “no” can sink substantive action, so you must pay keen attention to P5 positions. Security Council MUN simulations sometimes introduce crises or fast-paced developments, reflecting the UNSC’s ability to meet **at any time** when peace is threatened [16]. Overall, representing a country on the UNSC in MUN is both an honor and a test of diplomacy you must balance national positions with the need for collective action, all under the shadow of the veto.

2. Topic Overview: UNSC Reform

Historical context: Calls to reform the Security Council are nearly as old as the UN itself. The Council’s structure was set in 1945, when the UN had 51 members and a world dominated by a few great powers. Today the UN has 193 member states, yet the Council’s core composition of P5 permanents remains unchanged (aside from the replacement of China’s seat and Russia succeeding the USSR)[17]. In fact, the Council has been formally reformed only **once** in **1965**, when its membership expanded from 11 to 15 (adding four elected seats)[18][19]. That limited expansion did not alter the P5 or the veto. Since then, **global geopolitics have transformed** the colonial era ended, the Cold War came and went, and new economic powers emerged but the Council still reflects the power distribution of 1945[20]. This gap between the “world of 1945” and the “world of today” has fueled persistent demands for reform. Many diplomats, scholars, and states contend that the UNSC has become *unrepresentative* of the UN’s membership and current power realities [21] [20]. Notably, Africa, Asia, and Latin America have no permanent seats (other than China for Asia) despite comprising the majority of UN members and contributing heavily to UN peacekeeping and budget[22][23]. For example, over **70% of Security Council resolutions in recent years have concerned conflicts in Africa**, yet not a single African nation has a permanent voice or veto on the Council [24]. Such disparities raise concerns about the Council’s legitimacy and effectiveness in the 21st century.

Why reform is considered necessary: In essence, **credibility and effectiveness**. A Council whose composition ignores large parts of the world risks losing moral authority states are more likely to respect and implement Council decisions if they feel fairly represented in the decision-making. As Germany’s government put it, the Council must have “the necessary authority and legitimacy” to have its resolutions respected, which means it “**has to be representative**” of today’s geopolitical realities [25]. The current structure leaves **vast regions underrepresented** (no permanent member from Africa, the Middle East, Latin America, or Oceania) and excludes major contributors like India, Brazil, Japan, and others from permanent status[20][26]. Additionally, the **veto power** concentrated in five countries often leads to paralysis on urgent issues. In recent crises such as the Syrian civil war, Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, and the Israel-Palestine conflicts the Council has frequently been **deadlocked by vetoes or the threat of veto**[27][28]. This inaction undermines the Council’s core mandate to maintain peace. Critics argue that expanding membership and adjusting veto rules could make the UNSC *more responsive and democratic*, better reflecting “twenty-first century realities” and the rise of new powers[29][30]. Simply put, many UN members feel the Council’s structure is **outdated, unfair, and increasingly ineffective**, and that reform is essential to “enhance its representativeness, legitimacy, effectiveness, and efficiency”[29].

Key issues on the reform agenda: Since the early 1990s, UN members have debated several *linked* aspects of Security Council reform. In 2008, the General Assembly identified **five core issues** to be negotiated: **(1) categories of membership** (whether to add new permanent members, new non-permanent seats, or new types of seats), **(2) the question of the veto**, **(3) regional representation**, **(4) the overall size of an enlarged Council**, and **(5) the Council’s working methods and its relationship with the General Assembly**[31]. Virtually all countries agree in

principle on the need to reform, but they differ profoundly on how to do so. Over the past three decades, **several reform models** have emerged:

- **The G4 Proposal (1990s-2005):** Championed by the Group of Four nations India, **Brazil, Germany, Japan** this model calls for expanding the Council in **both** categories. In 2005 the G4 draft resolution proposed adding **6 new permanent seats** (two for Africa, two for Asia-Pacific, one for Latin America, one for Western Europe/others) **without immediate veto power for new permanents**, plus **4 new non-permanent seats** (one each for Africa, Asia-Pacific, Latin America, and Eastern Europe)[32]. This would expand the Council to 25 members. The G4 nations acknowledge that new permanent members likely would not have vetoes initially (as a politically necessary compromise), and suggested revisiting the veto question 15 years later in a review conference [33]. The G4 model has been a major focus of reform discussions, given that these four aspirants have broad support from many countries (and three of them are among the world's largest economies or populations).
- **The African Union's Ezulwini Consensus (2005):** The **55-member African Union (AU)** has a common position demanding at least **2 permanent seats for Africa** on the Council **with the same veto powers as existing P5** (if the veto remains), plus **2 additional non-permanent African seats**[34][35]. In effect, the AU proposal also enlarges the Council by roughly 11 seats (to 26 members) like the G4, it envisions 6 new permanents (Africa 2, Asia 2, Latin America 1, Western or developed nations 1) and slightly more non-permanents. However, the **veto issue is a major divergence**: the Ezulwini Consensus insists that either **the veto is abolished for all, or it must be granted to new permanent members as well "as a matter of justice"** [36]. African states argue they should not accept second-class permanent seats. This stance reflects both principle (equality) and strategy a fear that accepting permanents without veto might entrench an inferior status for new members. (Many other UN members, in contrast, would prefer no one have a veto rather than increase the number of veto-wielders.)
- **Uniting for Consensus (Fu) Proposal:** A coalition of about 1215 mid-sized countries including **Italy, Pakistan, Turkey, Mexico, Canada, South Korea, Argentina and others** formed the "Coffee Club," now known as **Uniting for Consensus**, explicitly to oppose new permanent seats for their regional rivals[37]. The Fu group advocates **zero** new permanent members; instead, they propose an expanded number of **elective seats**. For instance, past Fu plans have suggested adding around 10 **non-permanent seats** (potentially with longer renewable terms) [38] [39]. This would bring the Council to 25 members, all elected. Fu members argue this approach is more democratic and inclusive giving more countries a chance to serve and avoids creating new privileged permanent powers. They often propose innovative ideas like **"semi-permanent" seats**, which might be held by a country for an extended period (e.g. 3 or 4 years, possibly renewable) without being truly permanent. These ideas aim to accommodate influential countries without elevating them above the rest permanently. The downside, critics note, is that without permanents the Council might lack continuity and that major powers would still feel they deserve a constant presence.
- **High-Level Panel's Models (2004):** A UN-appointed High-Level Panel on Threats and Challenges proposed two illustrative reform models. **Model A** would add **6 new permanent seats** (with no new vetoes created) and **3 new two-year elected seats** [40]. **Model B** would add **no permanent seats**, but instead create **8 seats of four-year renewable terms** (a new category between permanent and 2-year seats) plus **1 additional 2-year seat** [40]. Both models enlarged the Council to 24 members. These Panel models significantly influenced subsequent debates, providing a semi-official blueprint, though neither was adopted.
- **Various Hybrid Ideas:** Other proposals have floated **regional seats** (e.g. a permanent seat for the **Arab states** or for **small island developing states** on a rotating basis), **"veto-light"** arrangements (discussed later), or **phased approaches** (expand membership now, tackle veto reform later). For example, the **Arab League** consistently demands a **permanent Arab seat** on any expanded Council [41], given that Arab countries currently must rely on elected seats alternating between Asia and Africa groups. Small states and middle powers have also pushed for improved **working methods** of the Council (greater transparency, restraint on veto use) even absent Charter amendment.

Current debates: Despite dozens of proposals and many General Assembly sessions spent on this topic, UN members have yet to agree on a single comprehensive reform plan. Since 2009, negotiations occur in an **open-ended Working Group and Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN)** format at the UN. Progress has been painstakingly slow often described as moving "at a glacial pace" (if not slower). Rival camps (G4, African Group, Fu, etc.) have essentially

deadlocked each other. Each proposal that elevates some countries invariably leaves others displeased (for instance, if India and Brazil become permanents, Pakistan and Argentina object). **No formula has secured the required supermajority support in the General Assembly without prompting a veto threat from at least one P5.** The last time a near-vote occurred was in 2005, when the G4 and AU came close to a compromise but ultimately split over veto issues; facing insufficient support, the draft resolutions were never brought to a final vote[42][43].

Nonetheless, momentum for reform has grown in recent years. The **frustrations of the Global South** have been more vocal for example, in 2023 the General Assembly President warned that without reform the Council's "effectiveness and legitimacy" will be further compromised [44]. World leaders at the 2023 and 2024 UNGA high-level debates, including officials from **Africa** and the **G4**, stressed the urgency of change, especially as great-power tensions are paralyzing the UN. Even some current P5 leaders have signaled openness: notably, **US President Joe Biden in 2022 called for Council enlargement, "adding more members from Africa, Latin America and the Caribbean,"** and urged P5 members to **refrain from excessive use of the veto** [45]. Similarly, **UK and French** officials have long supported expanding permanent membership to include countries like Germany, India, Japan, Brazil and African representatives [46]. Such endorsements, however, stop short of accepting any loss of their own privileges (France and the UK support others becoming permanent but also advocate voluntary veto restraint rather than abolishing veto).

In summary, Security Council reform remains a pressing but **elusive** goal. The need to make the Council more representative of today's geopolitical realities and more effective in handling crises is widely recognized. The challenge is that UN member states *cannot agree on the specifics* of expansion and veto reform, and any change ultimately requires the approval of the very powers who benefit from the status quo. The rest of this guide will delve into the two central reform aspects in our topic: **membership expansion** and **veto power reform**, examining the arguments, proposals, and positions of key stakeholders.

3. Membership Expansion

One major dimension of UNSC reform is whether to **expand the Council's membership**, especially by adding new **permanent seats**. This debate raises fundamental questions about representation, legitimacy, and efficiency in the UN's most powerful body. Below we explore the arguments on both sides, the regions and countries most actively seeking seats, the commonly proposed candidates, and the political feasibility of various expansion ideas.

Arguments for expanding membership:

- **Improving Representation and Legitimacy:** The current Council of 15 (with 5 permanents) is often criticized for failing to represent the UN's broad membership. Key regions have no permanent voice: for instance, **Africa (54 countries) has zero permanent seats**, and **Latin America & the Caribbean (33 countries) has none**. Many argue the Council's legitimacy suffers when entire continents and the Global South are excluded from permanent membership[22][24]. An expanded Council with more geographic diversity e.g. permanent seats for Africa, Latin America, and more Asia-Pacific representation would better reflect the world today and give affected regions a stake in decisions. This could make Council decisions more credible and universally respected.
- **Acknowledging Emerging Powers:** The world has changed since 1945 countries like **India (1.4+ billion people)**, **Brazil (world's 5th largest country by area)**, **Germany (a top financial contributor to the UN)**, **Japan (a leading economy)**, and others play enormous roles in international peace, security, and development[47][48]. Proponents say it's both logical and fair to acknowledge these contributions with permanent seats. Article 23 of the UN Charter even mentions that elected Council members should be chosen with regard to the "**contribution of Members to the maintenance of international peace and security**" [48]. By that criterion, the G4 countries (as well as, say, **South Africa or Nigeria** for Africa) merit a larger role. Expanding permanent membership would institutionalize the involvement of these major stakeholders, potentially enhancing the Council's problem-solving capacity (they bring resources, regional influence, etc.).
- **Enhancing Council Effectiveness:** Advocates argue that a **more representative Council would also be more effective**. When major powers or entire regions feel disenfranchised, they may be less inclined to accept or implement Council decisions, or they might bypass the UN entirely. For example, African states have sometimes questioned decisions made about African conflicts by a Council with no African permanent member to defend their interests. If countries like India, Brazil, or an African powerhouse were permanent members, they could lend their influence to broker regional peace deals and share the Council's burden in

maintaining security. *In theory*, greater inclusion of rising powers could also share the weight of global policing and conflict management (for instance, India and Brazil already contribute significantly to UN peacekeeping troops and budgets). A larger Council might bring **new perspectives and ideas**, improving decision-making for complex crises.

- **Moral and Historical Rationale:** There is also an argument of **correcting historical injustices** especially regarding Africa's absence among permanent members. The AU's Ezulwini Consensus notes that when the UN was founded, most of Africa was colonized and had no say; thus, not only is Africa now independent and deserving of seats, but the *Council's agenda has disproportionately focused on African conflicts without Africans at the table*[23][34]. Adding African permanent seats is seen as imperative to address this imbalance. Similarly, emerging economies that joined the UN later (or were on the losing side of WWII, like the Axis powers) argue that 80 years on, those old distinctions are no longer relevant to their contributions.

Arguments against or concerns about expansion:

- **Efficiency and Decision-Making:** A common concern is that a larger Council could become **unwieldy and less efficient**. The Council is deliberately small to allow quick, decisive action in crises. Critics worry that expanding to, say, 25 or 26 members might lead to **longer deliberations, more frequent deadlock, and diluted responsibilities**. The P5 often argue that an "over numbered" Council would struggle to reach agreement and "produce an inefficient and awkward organ" [49]. Each additional seat means another voice to negotiate with potentially complicating the already delicate consensus-building in the Council. (Of course, others counter that the current Council's paralysis is worse and that working methods can adjust to a modest size increase.)
- **Preserving Influence:** Some states particularly the current **P5 and regional rivals of aspirant countries** have a vested interest in **limiting the expansion**. Each new permanent member would somewhat dilute the influence of the existing P5 in Council dynamics (even without a veto, a permanent member has agenda-setting weight and a guaranteed presence). Naturally, the P5 are cautious about any reform that reduces their relative power. Meanwhile, countries like **Pakistan (rival of India), Italy (rival of Germany's bid), Argentina/Mexico (rivals of Brazil), Turkey (skeptical of more Western representation)** and others in the Uniting for Consensus coalition oppose expansion that doesn't include them. They claim that creating new "elite" seats will only widen inequality and rivalries. Instead, they prefer rotating seats that *they themselves* might occupy periodically. This self-interest-driven opposition is a major roadblock these nations actively lobby against G4 or other expansion proposals, making it hard to reach the required two-thirds support in the General Assembly for any specific plan.
- **Questioning Qualifications:** Another argument raised (often quietly) by some states is that **not all aspiring countries are "ready" or suitable for permanent status**. For instance, there have been suggestions that some potential new permanents (especially some African or smaller states) might **lack the economic/military clout or diplomatic network** to contribute meaningfully as permanent members [50]. Opponents in this vein argue that giving such countries a permanent seat "would be a waste of space and time" essentially putting the cart before the horse: let a region or country become a great power *first*, then give it a seat [50]. However, many criticize this as a flawed and even arrogant argument, pointing out that **historical injustices and lack of representation contribute to weaker capacity in the first place**, and that denying regions like Africa a seat perpetuates their marginalization [51]. In short, while *meritocracy* is cited, it's often entangled with maintaining the status quo.
- **Regional Rivalries and Zero-Sum Politics:** Expanding permanent seats raises the thorny issue of *which countries* get them. This can pit neighbors against each other. We see this in the **Latin American split** (Brazil seeks a seat, while Argentina and Mexico oppose Brazil's bid), in **East Asia** (Japan seeks a seat, but China and South Korea resist Japan due to historical grievances), and in the **Middle East** (some suggest a Muslim or Arab seat, which raises the question: which country holds it?). These rivalries mean any specific expansion model will have a bloc of opponents who feel left out. For example, adding India but not Pakistan, or Brazil but not Mexico, etc., can spur diplomatic pushback. Achieving a sense of *regional balance* in any expansion is extremely difficult there will always be more candidates than seats. This is a core reason the **Uniting for Consensus** bloc insists on no new permanents at all: it's the only way to avoid choosing winners and losers among regional peers (albeit at the cost of not actually resolving the representation deficit).

- **Legal Hurdle (Amending the Charter):** While not exactly an “argument” on merits, it’s important to recall that **to expand the Council, the UN Charter must be amended** (changing Article 23, which currently lists 5 permanent and 10 non-permanent seats). Charter amendment needs approval by two-thirds of the General Assembly **and ratification by two-thirds of member states including all P5**[52][53]. **This effectively gives each P5 a veto over reform, even if 190 out of 193 countries agreed. Thus, any expansion plan must be acceptable (or at least not objectionable) to all five current permanent members when it comes to ratification. This hugely constrains what is feasible for instance, a plan that the U.S. and China both dislike will simply not take effect. We will discuss P5 positions in the Stakeholders section, but suffice to say, this legal reality** means arguments against expansion often boil down to: “P5 X will never agree, so why bother?”**

Regions most demanding representation:

- **Africa:** As noted, Africa is the loudest voice for reform. The African Group (54 countries at the UN) has a near-unified stance: **Africa must have permanent seats** on the Council. The Committee of Ten (C-10) African Union states has been lobbying globally for this common African position [54]. They seek **at least 2 African permanent members** with veto (if veto remains) and **2 additional non-permanent** seats for Africa [34]. African leaders frequently underscore that over half of UNSC agenda items concern Africa, yet decisions are made **for Africa** without African nations at the power table [23]. They consider this a historic injustice and a practical impediment to peace solutions. Likely candidates for African permanent seats include the continent’s largest and most active nations in the UN: **Nigeria, South Africa, Egypt, Kenya, or Ethiopia** (the AU has not officially named them, to maintain unity). Notably, **the Ezulwini Consensus explicitly demands veto power for new African permanents** though some African diplomats privately signal they might accept a no-veto compromise if all P5 vetoes were suspended or if it were a transitional step [55]. As of 2023/2024, African demands have gained broader support; for the first time, **all five current P5** have (in principle) acknowledged Africa deserves greater representation, even if their specifics differ[30][56].
- **Latin America and the Caribbean:** This region currently has no permanent member (the United States is in the Americas but not Latin American). Latin American nations agree that the region deserves a stronger voice, but they *do not agree on who*. **Brazil** (the region’s largest country) is part of the G4 and a top contender for a permanent seat. It has support from many Portuguese and Spanish-speaking countries and beyond. However, **Mexico** and **Argentina**, leading the Fu in the region, oppose Brazil’s bid partly from national rivalry and partly ideological (preferring no new permanents). CARICOM (Caribbean states) and others generally support the idea of regional representation but often align with consensus positions like the L.69 Group (a broader developing countries coalition which includes many Latin and Caribbean states supporting expansion). Recently, U.S. official statements have oddly **supported a Latin American permanent seat but without explicitly naming Brazil** [57]. This suggests some hesitance (perhaps due to Brazil’s sometimes independent foreign policy). Nonetheless, Latin America is certainly pushing not to be left out if expansion happens **either Brazil or another Latin American** should get a permanent seat in their view. There have even been ideas of two Latin seats (though politically unlikely given limited total seats on offer).
- **Asia-Pacific:** Asia as a region already has China as a permanent member, but Asia-Pacific is hugely diverse and underrepresented relative to its population. The obvious aspirants here are **India** and **Japan**, both part of the G4. **India** is the world’s most populous nation and a nuclear-armed power with a long history of UN peacekeeping contributions. It has nearly universal support among developing countries (aside from its regional rival Pakistan) and endorsement from 4 of the P5 (USA, Russia, UK, France) notably **China has been more lukewarm**. **Japan** is a major donor (historically the UN’s #2 budget contributor) and a peaceful global actor, supported by Western countries; but it faces opposition from China and South Korea due to historical issues. There’s also discussion of greater **Muslim/Middle Eastern representation** for example, **Indonesia** (world’s largest Muslim-majority country) or an **Arab state** but no consensus on who. The **Arab League’s official stance** is that **the Arab States collectively should have one permanent seat** in an expanded Council [41]. How that would be implemented (perhaps a rotating Arab country occupying one permanent seat) is unresolved. Other Asia-Pacific mentions include **South Korea** (though it doesn’t actively seek a seat, focusing instead on opposing a seat for Japan unless broader consensus) and **Australia** (which as a middle power has occasionally been floated, but Australia itself supports the G4 position rather than pushing its own seat). **Small Island Developing States (SIDS)** in the Pacific also advocate that new arrangements account for very small nations’ voices for instance, some propose a dedicated rotating seat for SIDS in an enlarged Council [58].

- **Eastern Europe:** Eastern Europe is a bit of a special case. It currently has one non-permanent seat at any time (and Russia as a permanent). Countries like **Ukraine, Poland, and Romania** have at times claimed Eastern Europe deserves a second non-permanent seat due to its growth in membership after the Soviet Union's dissolution. In expansion proposals, Eastern Europe is often assigned 1 extra elected seat (as in the G4 plan) [59]. There was once speculation whether an EU seat could be created (replacing UK/France or in addition), but that's politically implausible (EU is not a country, and France/UK won't give up seats) [60]. By and large, Eastern Europe's main permanent seat claim might come from **Ukraine**, which has argued that Russia's use of the Soviet seat is illegitimate but realistically, Ukraine getting a permanent seat is not on the table absent a complete geopolitical upheaval. So Eastern Europe focuses on additional elected seats.
- **Middle East / Arab & Islamic representation:** As mentioned, Arab states feel underrepresented; no Arab country has ever been a permanent member. The idea of a **permanent "Arab" seat** (possibly rotating among Arab League members) has been raised by Arab diplomats in reform talks [41]. Similarly, the **Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)** (57 Muslim-majority states) has called for adequate Muslim representation on the Council [61] which overlaps with demands for Arab or broader developing world seats. While there's sympathy to these ideas, practically they would likely be satisfied if an Arab powerhouse like **Egypt** or **Saudi Arabia** got a permanent seat (Egypt is also Africa, Saudi is Asia-Arab). However, neither is a clear consensus choice: Egypt is supported in Africa, Saudi might be more controversial globally. **Turkey** and **Iran** also see themselves as influential Muslim states but each has its rivals. Thus, "Arab/Muslim representation" is a political hot potato often subsumed into other proposals (e.g. France has at times suggested one new seat should go to the Arab world [62]).
- **Other regions/groups: Western Europe and Others (WEOG)** already have 3 P5 (USA, UK, France) and often 2 elected seats. The G4 plan still allocates one new permanent for WEOG (intended for Germany) [59]. Some smaller Western nations (Canada, Spain, etc.) feel WEOG is already over-represented, which is why a permanent EU seat idea floats academically (but not practically, due to sovereignty issues). **Latin America and Caribbean (GRULAC)** we covered with Brazil vs opponents. **South Asia** beyond India Pakistan of course opposes India's solo bid and would prefer no permanents (or at least if India gets one, Pakistan argues that creates imbalance though few others support a Pakistani seat). **Africa** beyond the top contenders: countries like Kenya, Senegal, Tanzania, etc., have served as leaders in pushing the consensus but would presumably support whichever African states the AU endorses, likely rotating among sub regions.

Commonly proposed new permanent candidates: Summarizing the usual suspects, often named in reform debates: the **G4 nations (India, Brazil, Germany, Japan)** are the most explicitly campaigned-for permanent seats. **Two African countries** (widely presumed to be from among Nigeria, South Africa, Egypt, Kenya, or Ethiopia) are proposed in both G4 and AU models. That makes potentially $4 + 2 = \text{six new permanent members}$. The **United States, UK, and France** have all indicated support (in general terms) for these additions: for example, the UK in 2024 explicitly called for adding **Brazil, Germany, India, Japan, and "African representation"** as permanent members [63]. France similarly calls it "abnormal" that Africa isn't represented and backs adding the G4 and Africa [64]. The U.S. has voiced support for **India and (by implication) an African presence**, and recently also said **Germany and Japan and some Latin American representation** should be included (though the U.S. was coy about Brazil specifically) [30]. **Russia and China** have each at least endorsed **India** (both have publicly supported India's bid in some form) [46], and generally say they support a greater role for developing countries (China emphasizes Africa, Russia has mentioned Brazil favorably at times, and both Russia/China might prefer more Global South friends on the Council to counterbalance Western influence). However, Russia and China also have reservations about Japan, Germany, etc., and prefer consensus.

In addition to those six, **one seat for Latin America** (Brazil in G4 plan) and **one for the Arab/Middle East** (not explicitly in G4 plan, but France has suggested possibly an Arab-world rotating permanent seat in the future [62]) are sometimes mentioned. The High-Level Panel's Model A distribution was 6 new permanents across **major regions** essentially the same six: 2 Africa, 2 Asia, 1 Europe (likely Germany), 1 Americas (Brazil).

It's worth noting that over time, **the G4 and Africa have in principle agreed to support each other's bids** the G4 explicitly back **"at least 2 African permanent seats"** [65], and the AU has indicated support for **two of the G4 (India and Brazil) plus one seat for the Latin America/Caribbean region and one more for either WEOG or Asia** in some past discussions, provided Africa gets its due. However, the **lack of consensus on veto and on which countries** in Africa remain sticking points between these groups.

Political challenges and feasibility:

Expanding membership requires an extraordinary level of agreement not only among the 193 UN member states to achieve a two-thirds majority (128+ votes) for a reform resolution, but also among the **five current permanent members, who must ratify the Charter amendment**[52][53]. This double threshold has proven insurmountable so far. Key challenges include:

- P5 Resistance:** Any expansion dilutes the exclusivity of the P5 club. While the UK and France are quite open (seeing Council expansion as inevitable and potentially beneficial for burden-sharing), the other three US, **Russia, China** have been more resistant in practice. They may support the concept of some expansion but **none of them has formally committed to a specific package** of countries. Each P5 has its hesitations (China about Japan and India; US historically had concerns about rivals or too anti-US countries getting in; Russia and China both fear more Western-aligned members; the US fears more Russian/Chinese-aligned members a bit of a Cold War redux). All P5 *enjoy* a Council where they can often sway the 10 elected members to build coalitions; adding more heavyweights could reduce P5 leverage. Most critically, **all P5 strongly oppose any change that touches their veto power or permanent status** (more on that in veto section). So while P5 might allow more permanents without veto, they will not allow any reform that threatens their own veto or could create a rival bloc to outvote them.
- The Veto of Vetoes:** As a wry saying goes, *“The Security Council can’t reform itself because any real reform can be vetoed by those who benefit from no reform.”* Technically, vetoes don’t apply in the General Assembly voting stage (amendments in GA are one-country-one-vote), but **in the ratification stage, each P5 has a de facto veto** (if a P5’s legislature doesn’t ratify the amendment, it fails) [53]. This hangs over negotiations. For instance, even if 140 countries agreed on a plan to give new permanents limited veto, if **one P5 (say, China or Russia) dislikes that India or Japan is included, they can simply refuse to ratify**, killing the reform. Thus, *feasible* reform options tend to be those that the current P5 can live with. This might mean a *smaller expansion* than many want, and no new veto powers. You must grapple with what compromises could secure P5 acquiescence essentially, persuading the foxes to let a few more into the henhouse without eating them.
- Competing regional interests:** We saw how **regional rivalries** create a coordination problem. To get 128+ GA votes, a proposal must balance various regions’ demands so that *enough* countries support it. Every additional permanent seat for one country can lose several votes from its neighbors. In 2005, for example, the **G4 proposal** had around 80 confirmed supporters initially; the **African Union’s proposal** had its own base; and the **Uniting for Consensus** had another each far from the 128 needed, and they mutually prevented consensus. Compromise has been elusive: the G4 tried offering no immediate veto and a review (to appease others), the Africans have refused to budge on veto equality, and the Fu simply says “no permanents.” The result: stalemate. Negotiations in the IGN often bog down with each group restating positions.
- Numbers game:** How many seats to add is itself contentious. If the Council becomes too large (say 30 members), many fear it would lose effectiveness. On the other hand, too small an expansion (like adding only 2 or 4 seats) might not satisfy demands. Most proposals cluster around 2127 total members. But choosing, say, **6 new permanents and 4 non-permanents** means *some* regions get more than others inevitably causing unhappiness. There’s also the matter of **elected seats**: some countries that often get elected currently (like smaller states from various regions) fear that if permanent seats multiply, there will be fewer elected spots open for rotation. For example, if India and Japan become permanent, the Asia-Pacific group’s two elected seats might then mostly rotate among smaller Asian states some smaller Asia-Pacific states support India/Japan’s bid, but others worry it’ll be harder for them to ever sit on the Council. Similarly, Africa currently always has 3 elected seats; if two big African countries take permanent seats, **will the remaining 2 or 3 elected African seats be enough for the other 50+ African countries to cycle through?** These concerns make some states lukewarm on expansion unless it also increases non-permanent seats.
- Feasibility of intermediate solutions:** Some observers propose **“semi-permanent” or rotating permanent seats by region** as a compromise. For example, instead of naming India outright as a permanent member, have a **permanent seat for Asia** that could rotate among major Asian nations on a longer-term basis. Or a **combined Latin America/Caribbean permanent seat** that could alternate between Brazil and, say, an elected Latin representative. Such creative ideas aim to bypass picking a single “winner” country. However, implementing them is complex and would likely require *those countries* to agree to share a seat which aspirants are reluctant to do after investing so much in their campaigns. Still, intermediate options might gain traction if all-or-nothing proposals keep failing.

- **General Assembly impatience:** There is talk among some UN members of **forcing a vote** on a reform resolution even if consensus is not achieved, just to put countries on record. Indeed, in 2023 the G4 and some allies pushed to start **text-based negotiations** (rather than endless talk). Opponents (Fu) resist this, since a text would eventually lead to a yes/no choice. The danger of forcing a vote without near-consensus is that if it fails to get 2/3, it could set back momentum. But if frustration grows, we could see a partial measure or a procedural vote to shake things up.

In sum, **expanding the Council's membership is a contentious balancing act**. Many compelling arguments support it fairness, legitimacy, incorporating rising powers yet realpolitik and institutional inertia have so far prevailed. You in this committee will need to consider creative formulas and compromises. Can new permanent seats be added in a way that satisfies regional balance and gets P5 buy-in? If not, are there alternative paths (more non-permanents, or a new category of seats) that could serve as a stepping stone? The next section will examine the equally thorny issue of the **veto power**, which is deeply intertwined with the question of new permanent members (since who gets a veto is a make-or-break point of contention).

Table: Key Security Council Expansion Proposals (for reference)

Proposal	New Permanent Seats	New Seats	Non-Permanent	Veto for Permanents?	New	Total Council Size
<i>Current (2023)</i>	5 (P5) USA, UK, France, Russia, China	10 (elected, 2-year terms)		P5 only		15 members
G4 Proposal (2005)	+6 (India, Japan, Germany, Brazil, 2×Africa)[59]	+4 (1 each for Africa, Asia-Pacific, Am/Carib, Europe)[59]		No (deferred review)[33]	15-year	25 members
African Union (Ezulwini, 2005)	+6 (2×Africa, 2×Asia, 1×Latin Am, 1×WEOG)	+5 (to increase African and other regional rotation)		Yes (veto for all permanents or abolish for all)[66]		26 members
Uniting for Consensus	+0 (no new permanents)	+10 (new 2-year or possibly some longer-term seats)[38]		N/A (no permanents)	new	~25 members
High-Level Panel Model A (2004)	+6 (no additional vetoes)	+3		No new (implicitly)	veto	24 members
High-Level Panel Model B (2004)	+0 permanents, +8 semi-permanent (4-year renewable seats)	+1 (additional 2-year seat)		N/A (no permanents)	new	24 members

(WEOG = *Western Europe & Others*; *semi-permanent* = *longer-term elected seats*.)

4. Restricting or Modifying the Veto Power

The **veto power** the ability of any one of the five permanent members to block substantive Council action lies at the heart of the Security Council's unique authority and its biggest controversies. Efforts to reform the Council often include proposals to **limit, curtail, or redefine the veto**, since many UN members view the veto as anachronistic or subject to abuse. In this section, we review the origin and function of the veto, criticisms of its current use, and various reform ideas ranging from voluntary restraint to formal amendments. We'll also consider the reactions of the current P5 to any changes in the veto regime.

History and legal basis of the veto: The veto was baked into the UN's architecture from the start. At the 194445 conferences in Dumbarton Oaks and Yalta that designed the UN, the great powers (US, UK, USSR, China, and France) **insisted on having veto rights** as the price of their participation. They remembered the League of Nations, where every Council member (including small powers) had a veto and decision-making became impossible with so many veto-wielders [67]. The UN founders' logic was: *to keep the peace, the new Security Council needed the great powers onboard; therefore nothing major should happen if a great power strongly objected*. Article 27 of the UN Charter enshrines this: **substantive**

decisions require “the concurring votes of the permanent members” (plus a total of at least 9 yes votes)[9][68]. In practice, “concurring” means a P5 can veto by voting no (an abstention by a P5 is not counted as a veto) [10]. The word “veto” doesn’t appear in the Charter, but Article 27(3) effectively provides it [68]. Thus, since 1945, the five permanent members each hold an **absolute negative** on any Council resolution dealing with non-procedural matters (e.g. sanctions, peacekeeping mandates, condemnations of aggression, etc.).

The rationale given was that **this would foster cooperation among the great powers and prevent the UN from taking actions that might lead to direct conflict with them**[69]. The P5 were to act as “**world policemen**” working in concert, and the veto was a safeguard to ensure none of them would be forced by UN vote into a war against themselves or their allies [14]. Indeed, as the French Foreign Ministry notes, the veto was supposed to carry with it a “duty” a special responsibility to seek peace, not a mere privilege to be used arbitrarily[70]. However, in the real world, the veto (and threat of veto) has also been used to protect P5 national interests even when it paralyzes the Council.

Use and critiques of the current veto system: Since 1946, the veto has been used **over 290 times** (the count reached 262 by 2022 and continues to rise) [71] [46↑look] . During the Cold War, vetoes were frequent (mainly by the USSR, and by the US on certain issues). After a relatively quiet 1990s, veto use has surged again in recent years for instance, Russia and China have vetoed many resolutions on Syria; the US has vetoed resolutions on Israel-Palestine (including very recently on Gaza); Russia vetoed action on its own invasion of Ukraine, etc.[72] [28]. Some notable impacts of vetoes include: the UN’s inability to intervene to stop the **1994 Rwandan genocide** (due to threatened French veto at the time), paralysis during the **Syrian civil war** (with over a dozen Russia/China vetoes since 2011), and in 2022, Russia’s veto of a resolution condemning its invasion of Ukraine[73][74]. Each P5 has wielded the veto at times to shield either itself or an ally: e.g. the **US has used its veto 50+ times to protect Israel** from critical resolutions[75][76]; Russia (and previously USSR) has vetoed issues from the Korean War to the Balkans to recently, blocking even referrals of Syria or Ukraine to international courts[77][73]; China has vetoed actions especially when it sees a threat to state sovereignty or its interests (Taiwan, Myanmar, etc.), though historically China used the veto sparingly until the 2000s[78]; France and UK used vetoes in the Cold War era (e.g. France over its colonies, UK over Rhodesia), but notably **neither France nor the UK has exercised a veto since 1989**[78] they now emphasize cooperation and have voluntarily restrained themselves.

The **critique of the veto** is multi-fold:

- **Democratic Deficit:** The veto is inherently undemocratic one country’s objection outweighs the will of potentially 14 others on the Council and indeed the majority of the international community. Critics call it a “**charter-sanctioned inequality**” that contradicts the principle of sovereign equality of states. As one delegate quipped, the veto amounts to saying “**All nations are equal, but some are more equal than others.**”
- **Impediment to Peace:** Vetoes (or the threat of them) often **block the Council from acting to prevent atrocities or end conflicts**. The Council can only be effective if it acts; when resolutions are killed by veto, the UN seems impotent. E.g., many believe action in Syria (chemical weapons use, humanitarian access) was stymied by repeated vetoes, costing lives and credibility. **Genocide prevention** advocates decry that the veto has prevented timely intervention in mass atrocity situations [15]. Essentially, *the veto is seen as the chief cause of Council inaction where action is needed* [15].
- **Politicization and Double Standards:** P5 members have used vetoes to defend their own military actions or those of their allies, leading to accusations of **double standards**. For instance, Russia’s veto on Ukraine, or U.S. vetoes on Israel issues, suggest that when a P5 or its close friend is involved, the Council’s hands are tied undermining the idea of collective security. This selective application corrodes the UN’s moral authority.
- **Outdated Power Structure:** The veto power freeze-frames the geopolitical realities of 1945. Not only are no new veto-wielding powers included (see expansion debate), but the original five’s privileged status looks increasingly **out of touch** with today’s multipolar world. Many UN members consider the veto an **anachronism** a relic that has no place in a more democratic 21st-century global governance [79].

At the same time, it’s important to note that **supporters of the veto** (usually the P5 themselves, and some who fear UN overreach) argue the veto plays a stabilizing role: *It ensures the UN does not enact binding decisions that major powers would flagrantly defy*. They contend that if, say, Russia or the U.S. could be legally bound by a Council resolution against its will, those powers might simply ignore the UN or withdraw, destroying the UN’s relevance [14]. Russia and China often claim the veto is a **check on Western interventionism**, preventing military adventures under UN cover that they see as

infringing sovereignty [14]. Smaller states sometimes quietly appreciate that *at least one P5 will veto an extreme action, preventing the UN from being dragged into dangerous conflicts*. These arguments reflect the original logic of great-power unanimity.

In reform discussions, however, nearly all countries outside the P5 voice some desire to **curb veto use**. The challenge is *how* to do so given the Charter's requirements.

Existing reform ideas for the veto:

1. **Voluntary Veto Restraint Code of Conduct:** One prominent approach has been **asking the P5 to refrain from using the veto in certain situations**, rather than trying to legally abolish it (which the P5 would veto!). In 2015, a group of states called the ACT (Accountability, Coherence, Transparency) group proposed a “**Code of Conduct regarding Security Council action against genocide, crimes against humanity or war crimes**.” Under this voluntary pledge, **all Council members (including P5)** who sign would commit **not to vote against** any credible draft resolution aimed at preventing or halting mass atrocity crimes [80]. To date, this **ACT Code of Conduct** has been supported by around 120 member states (including two P5: **France and the UK** are supporters) [81]. Separately, in 2013 France spearheaded a similar initiative specifically for the P5. The **France-Mexico initiative** calls for the P5 to **collectively agree to suspend use of the veto in cases of genocide, mass atrocities, or large-scale war crimes**[82][83]. President Macron of France announced in 2015 that France would unilaterally not use its veto in such situations [84]. As of January 2023, **105 countries had signed on** to the France-Mexico political declaration supporting veto restraint in atrocity cases[85][86]. The idea here is moral pressure: if enough nations (and public opinion) push, perhaps the P5 (at least some of them) will feel obliged to rarely or never veto actions to stop genocides or crimes against humanity. Indeed, the UK and France have essentially observed this (neither has vetoed in decades, and they endorse restraint). The U.S., Russia, and China have **not** signed on those three have been more reluctant, citing concerns that criteria could be misused or erode their rights. Nonetheless, voluntary veto restraint is one of the more *realistically achievable* reforms since it doesn't require Charter change.
2. **Limiting the Scope of the Veto:** Some proposals suggest formally **restricting when the veto can be used**. For example, one idea is to **prohibit veto use in situations of mass atrocities** (similar to above but making it an official rule). Others have mooted that a P5 should not veto resolutions addressing conflicts to which that P5 is a party (to avoid clear conflicts of interest). However, any binding rule like this would need Charter amendment which the P5 would likely veto/oppose. Another notion is requiring **veto “justifications”** e.g. a rule that when casting a veto, a P5 must publicly explain the rationale in a formal setting. This is partly addressed by a new General Assembly initiative (discussed below), but not a Charter requirement.
3. **Supermajority or Override Mechanisms:** More ambitious reformers have proposed altering the veto system so that a single P5 “no” does not automatically kill a resolution if there is overwhelming support otherwise. For example, one concept is a “**double veto**” **requirement** i.e. it would take at least two (or perhaps three) P5 vetoes to block a resolution. A single veto could be overridden if all other 14 Council members vote yes (or if enough of the other P5 concur). Another idea: a **General Assembly override** if the Council is vetoed on an important issue, the GA could take up the matter and override the veto with a high majority (this is somewhat akin to the *Uniting for Peace* resolution mechanism used in the Korean War and more recently for Ukraine, where the GA steps in when the Council is paralyzed, but GA resolutions are non-binding). Any formal override mechanism again would need Charter change. The likelihood of P5 agreeing to dilute their veto in this way is very low. However, these ideas feature in academic and diplomatic debates as ideals to strive for in the future. They reflect a desire to make the Council more democratic: if 14 out of 15 members support something, one holdout shouldn't stop it completely.
4. **Phased Reduction or Elimination of Veto:** Some envision a long-term process where the veto could be phased out entirely. One hypothetical path: first agree to no new vetoes for new permanent members (which seems likely if expansion occurs), then over time build consensus to gradually limit the existing P5 veto (for instance, initially removing it on thematic issues, or requiring P5 to abstain when they are party to a conflict), and eventually amend the Charter to remove veto power altogether. This is admittedly a very distant prospect. **Many smaller states and some principled middle powers actually favor abolishing the veto** on principle one country, one vote. But **all P5 are firmly against any formal loss of veto**, so unless global power dynamics shift dramatically (or a review conference is convened under Article 109, which still would need P5

buy-in), this remains aspirational. The AU's Ezulwini position even acknowledges this by saying: ideally veto abolished, but if not, give it to all permanents (so at least it's equal) [34].

5. **Procedural Accountability Measures:** Short of changing the veto itself, measures have been adopted to hold veto-users more accountable. In April 2022, the **General Assembly adopted a landmark resolution (A/RES/76/262)** often called the “Veto Initiative” which **mandates that the GA automatically convene a debate whenever a veto is cast in the Security Council**[87][88]. This means if any P5 blocks a resolution, they will have to face the entire UN membership in an open GA session and explain why they did so. The idea is to shine a spotlight on veto use and perhaps deter frivolous or isolated vetoes. The resolution, co-sponsored by around 83 countries (including the US, UK, and France interestingly; Russia and China did not co-sponsor), passed by consensus [89]. While this doesn't limit the veto legally, it increases political costs a P5 must publicly defend its veto in front of potentially critical peers and media. Already, this mechanism has been triggered after vetoes on e.g. Syria and Gaza issues, bringing more scrutiny. Some see this as a modest but meaningful step toward **greater transparency** and pressure on veto-wielders [88] [90]. Critics note it still “has no teeth” it doesn't stop the veto, just talks about it[90]. Nonetheless, it reflects growing frustration and creativity from the wider UN membership in addressing veto abuse.
6. **No Veto for New Members:** If the Council expands, one almost certain condition (at least for initial decades) is that **any new permanent members would *not* be given the veto**. All serious expansion proposals except the African Union's explicitly say new permanents will not have veto power, at least initially[33]. The G4 accepted this trade-off (preferring a permanent seat without veto to no seat at all, for now). Some countries argue this simply creates tiered permanents and is fundamentally unfair; others say it's the only politically viable way to get P5 not to torpedo expansion. In any case, this is a likely feature of any near-term reform: **the P5 would remain the only veto-holders**. Over the long term, there could be a review (e.g. G4 proposed a review after 15 years to discuss veto extension or elimination)[33]. *You should consider:* would a Council with more permanent members but only P5 vetoes be an improvement? It might reduce the relative power of each veto (since more members total means a veto doesn't override as large a majority percentage-wise), but the fundamental issue of the P5's privileged veto remains.

Reactions of current P5 states:

Any discussion of veto reform must reckon with how the P5 themselves view it, since they hold the keys. In brief:

- **United States:** The U.S. historically guarded its veto jealously, particularly during the Cold War and on Israel-related issues. It has used veto second-most after Russia/USSR[75]. However, the U.S. also tries to avoid standing alone; it values the Council's legitimacy, so a lone U.S. veto (especially on humanitarian issues) can be diplomatically costly. In recent years, American officials (including President Biden) have acknowledged that the veto is overused and called for restraint[91]. The U.S. co-sponsored the 2022 GA veto transparency initiative[89], signaling support for accountability. But would the U.S. ever give up or formally limit its veto? Unlikely in the near term. Washington has **not endorsed** the French veto code of conduct (perhaps concerned about tying its hands on issues like Israel). The U.S. is open to voluntary restraint in principle. Biden's UN speech suggested P5 should not veto except in rare cases but the U.S. wants to keep its flexibility. For new members, the U.S. position is clear: it **supports no new vetoes** being created[57][92]. In fact, the U.S. indicated it would only back expanding permanents if those new seats come **without** veto rights[93]. So any expansion acceptable to the U.S. involves a continuation of only the P5 having vetos.
- **United Kingdom and France:** The two Western European P5 have somewhat progressive views on veto reform (perhaps because they use it least now). Both UK and France have signed on to veto restraint initiatives. **France** initiated the atrocity veto restraint idea and **unilaterally pledged not to use its veto in mass atrocity cases**[84]. **The UK** also supports the code of conduct (though it historically used veto on specific issues, it hasn't since 1989). Neither wants to abolish the veto entirely (at least not until/unless global conditions radically change), but they often speak in favor of P5 “responsibility” and careful use of veto. They both co-sponsored the GA debate mechanism resolution, meaning they're willing to explain their veto if used (which, given they haven't used it in decades, is mostly theoretical). For **new permanent members**, the UK and France have accepted that those would likely have no veto initially. Interestingly, France at one point was unique among P5 in saying it wouldn't object if new permanents eventually got veto after a review[62], but more recently France aligns with the consensus of no new vetoes (France's 2023 statement explicitly said they *do not support extending veto to new members*[56]). In summary, London and Paris are amenable to voluntary veto

limits but not to stripping their own veto by Charter amendment. They likely would **not veto an expansion that leaves their veto intact and improves Council representativeness**, as long as it doesn't create an unwieldy Council.

- **Russia:** Russia (and before 1991, the Soviet Union) is the **most frequent veto user** historically[75]. For Moscow, the veto is a vital tool to protect its interests and allies. Russia vetoed a resolution condemning its invasion of Ukraine, as well as many on Syria, so it clearly values having this shield[73]. Russian officials defend the veto as ensuring **international stability and preventing Western dominance**[14]. They often point out that without veto, the US could have driven the UN to approve interventions Russia sees as illegitimate. Russia has been wary of any move that even symbolically erodes veto power. It did not support the GA's veto debate resolution (likely seeing it as targeting Russia after the Ukraine veto). In Council reform talks, Russia has said it's open to a *moderate expansion* (it has expressed willingness to see India, perhaps Brazil, maybe an African like South Africa, join as permanents)[94], but **with no new vetoes** and a preference that the Council not grow too large[49]. Importantly, **Russia would almost certainly oppose any formal restriction of its veto** via Charter amendment. It views veto as a redline perhaps the single most significant leverage Russia has in world affairs today is its P5 veto. So while Russia might agree informally to exercise restraint (in theory), it will not give up the right. Moscow frequently reminds others that in 1963's Council expansion, even countries that voted against still ratified the change, implying P5 can be pragmatic if their core power (veto) isn't touched[42][95]. In essence: Russia will block any change that limits P5 veto rights, but might allow expansion without new vetoes.
- **China:** China generally echoes Russia in championing the veto as protecting sovereignty and preventing rash interventions. China has historically used the veto less than other P5, but lately has been more willing to do so (often alongside Russia)[78]. Beijing strongly opposes any Charter changes to the veto. Chinese diplomats often say the Council's authority would be undermined if veto rights are diluted. They are on record cautioning that **reforms must prioritize the Council's effectiveness**, implying too many veto players or limitations could paralyze it further[96]. China did not sign on to the French/Mexican initiative or ACT code, and did not co-sponsor the GA veto debate resolution. However, interestingly, China has joined consensus on some GA statements encouraging P5 not to use veto in cases of mass atrocities but that's more aspirational. On expansion, China is fine with no new vetoes (in fact, it prefers new permanents don't weaken P5 privilege). It is likely to oppose any scenario where say India gets a veto (given China-India rivalry).

In summary, **the P5 as a group are united on one thing: preserving their veto prerogative under the Charter**. While some (UK, France, US) may voluntarily reduce use or support procedural tweaks, none will consent to an amendment curtailing the veto power they individually hold[97]. As the German government's FAQ bluntly notes: *even if new permanents are added, the existing five must also ratify any Charter amendment, giving them an "even stronger absolute veto over any change to the absolute veto power"*[98]. Any delegate's plans to legally remove or override the veto will run into this brick wall of realpolitik.

Therefore, the more **pragmatic focus** has been on measures like **voluntary agreements, political pressure, and cultural norms** to tame the veto's use. The adoption of the **2022 GA veto accountability resolution** is a concrete example of the UN membership finding a way *around* the Charter limitation by using the GA's authority to call out vetoes[88]. It doesn't eliminate the veto but it chips away at the impunity with which it can be wielded.

Existing reform proposals on veto (summary):

- *Keep veto but voluntarily restrain it:* Encourage P5 to agree not to use veto in cases of mass atrocities (ACT Code, France-Mexico pledge). Status: Ongoing campaign, significant support, but not universal among P5 (Russia/China resistant, US ambiguous).
- *Don't extend veto to new members:* This is widely accepted as likely, to ensure P5 accept expansion. New permanent members would join as non-veto-wielding permanents (at least initially)[33]. This makes expansion more palatable to current P5, but creates a two-tier Council (P5 vs others).
- *Require multiple vetoes:* Amend Charter so that e.g. 2 P5 vetoes are needed to block. This idea floats in discussions but no formal movement any attempt to amend Charter in this way would be vetoed by at least one P5 (since it directly reduces individual P5 power).

- *GA override or “Uniting for Peace” use:* While not an official reform of SC, the GA has authority under *Uniting for Peace* (Res. 377 (V) of 1950) to recommend collective measures when the Council fails due to veto. This was used in the Korean War and more recently in Ukraine 2022 (GA Emergency Special Session condemning the invasion after Russia’s veto). Some suggest strengthening the linkage: perhaps automatically referring issues to GA if vetoed in SC. The 2022 resolution partly does this by requiring a GA meeting after a veto[88]. This doesn’t give GA binding power, but it does keep the issue alive.
- *Eliminate veto entirely:* Favored in rhetoric by many small/medium countries and civil society, but no realistic path as it needs P5 consent. Only way could be via an Article 109 Charter Review Conference theoretically forced by GA and 7 SC votes but even that requires P5 ratification at the end[99]. So elimination remains a distant goal.

In considering **veto reform in our committee’s context**, you have options mostly on the **soft-law or diplomatic side**: e.g. resolution language supporting the ACT Code of Conduct (urging all states to sign on), calling on the remaining P5 to join the veto restraint pledge, or perhaps **endorsing the idea that P5 should explain their vetoes to the GA** (backing the new GA mechanism). They could also propose creative norms like a **“gentlemen’s agreement”** that if two or more P5 support a draft, the others won’t veto it on principle (this is somewhat fanciful as a formal thing, but could be hinted at). Another avenue: improve **Security Council working methods** so that vetoes are less likely for instance, more use of informal negotiation to address P5 concerns pre-vote, or splitting resolutions to isolate contentious veto-triggering elements from consensus parts.

A specific, interesting proposal from Liechtenstein’s ambassador (who led the GA veto initiative) is to require the **Permanent Member exercising a veto to at least attend the GA debate** about it and provide an explanation this isn’t legally required, but politically expected now[90]. Perhaps our committee could reinforce that expectation.

Implications of veto reform for Council effectiveness: If veto use were curbed (even voluntarily), the Council might be able to act more often in crises that currently see deadlock. For example, had the no-veto-in-atrocity pledge been in effect, perhaps the Council could have authorized measures to protect civilians in Syria or Myanmar where today such efforts are vetoed. However, **P5 buy-in is critical** if they feel their core interests threatened, they might ignore any voluntary pledge when the moment comes (since it’s unenforceable except by reputation cost).

In any event, **combining membership expansion with veto reform** is tricky: many UN members say *both* must be addressed (for instance, adding permanents without doing something about the veto leaves the root problem of Council paralysis in certain cases). Others argue politically it’s easier to expand membership first (with new permanents having no veto) and deal with veto reform gradually through practice and pressure.

As you, you may explore **middle-ground ideas** like a *conditional veto suspension*: e.g. a mechanism where if a certain number of Council members or perhaps the Secretary-General determine a situation is a genocide or atrocity, P5 agree not to veto. France’s proposal even suggested empowering the Secretary-General to trigger the veto-suspension mechanism when 50+ member states request action in a mass atrocity[100]. That still relies on voluntary agreement, but it’s a structured approach.

Another idea: **“veto pre-notification”** P5 could be encouraged to declare early if they intend to veto a draft, to avoid futile exercises and allow alternative solutions (addressing the so-called “hidden veto” problem where drafts are never tabled due to anticipated veto[71]). More transparency there could help other Council members pivot to other actions (like calling an Emergency Session of GA instead, or framing the issue differently).

In conclusion, **restricting the veto** is arguably the most difficult piece of UNSC reform because it directly challenges P5 privileges. Progress will likely be incremental and normative rather than via Charter amendment in the foreseeable future. Yet, for many UN members, some check on the veto is essential if the Council is to function better and more equitably. As we move to stakeholder positions, remember that any proposal on veto must be carefully calibrated to stand a chance of acceptance the art may lie in finding **innovative voluntary regimes** or **creative use of GA authority** to constrain veto misuse without formally changing the Charter (at least in the short term).

5. Stakeholder Positions

In debating UNSC reform, it’s crucial to understand where the major actors and groups of states stand. Here we outline detailed, evidence-based positions of key stakeholders:

- **The P5 Countries (Current Permanent Members):**

- United States:** The U.S. supports a **modest expansion** of the Security Council, with an emphasis on adding **like-minded and regionally diverse powers**. In recent statements, Washington has backed the idea of new permanent seats for **Africa (at least two)**, as well as for **Japan, India, and Germany**, and a seat for **Latin America** (which implicitly means Brazil, although U.S. officials have sometimes avoided naming Brazil explicitly)[30][45]. President Biden told the UN in 2022 that the U.S. endorses Council enlargement, “**particularly by adding more members from Africa and Latin America and the Caribbean**”[45]. This is a notable shift previous U.S. administrations were cooler on expansion. The U.S. sees value in broadening representation to bolster the Council’s credibility, and perhaps to counter accusations of Western domination. However, the U.S. has **firm conditions: no extension of veto to new members**[57] and the Council should not grow so large as to be ineffective. Indeed, U.S. diplomats have indicated they’d only consider about **5-6 new permanent seats** and maybe a few additional elected seats[101]. The U.S. also emphasizes that any candidates must be “responsible stakeholders” (e.g. democracies, contributors to UN peacekeeping, etc.). That’s one reason the U.S. clearly supports **India and Japan** (strategic partners in Indo-Pacific), **Germany** (a NATO ally), and has at times had ambivalence about **Brazil** (due to its independent stances and regional politics though Brazil is still the likeliest Latin American choice). On **veto reform**, the U.S. position is cautiously open to **voluntary restraint** but not legal changes. The U.S. co-sponsored the GA initiative to have debates after vetoes, signaling it is okay with more scrutiny[89]. Biden’s call for P5 to “refrain from use of the veto except in rare, extraordinary situations” suggests the U.S. at least rhetorically acknowledges criticism of veto abuse[91]. Yet, Washington has not signed the France/Mexico veto pledge likely because it wants to preserve its veto use in cases it deems critical (notably to shield Israel or its own actions). In summary, the U.S. will **support expansion** if it sees friendly powers gaining seats (and no adversaries), and it will **oppose any loss of its own veto** though it’s willing to encourage others (and itself) to use veto less often. Importantly, the U.S. wants any reform to enhance the Council’s ability to act, not hinder it so it stresses “effective and credible” reform over just symbolic inclusivity[30].
- United Kingdom:** The UK has long been one of the most vocal P5 supporters of Council reform. It publicly supports the **G4 and African Union aspirations**. Britain’s stance is that **Germany, Japan, India, and Brazil** should become permanent members, alongside **two permanent African seats**[46]. As a close ally to two G4 (Germany and Japan) and a proponent of Commonwealth partners like India, the UK finds it logical these countries join the P5 at the table. London often notes that it hasn’t vetoed anything since 1989, implying it doesn’t jealously guard using that power. The UK has joined France in the **veto restraint pledge** for mass atrocities and has encouraged other P5 to follow suit[85]. It co-sponsored the GA veto accountability resolution, showing openness to the new system of explaining vetoes[89]. On expansion specifics, the UK also supports adding **additional non-permanent seats** to ensure smaller states still get opportunities on the Council[59]. UK officials have suggested the Council size could go up to around 25-26 without losing effectiveness. Critically, like all P5, the UK does **not advocate giving new members the veto** UK diplomats explicitly say new permanents could join “*initially without veto*” and that the veto issue can be revisited only in the context of broader agreement (in practice, the UK knows new vetoes won’t fly)[33]. The UK also currently holds one of the P5 seats representing the Western European group, yet it supports another WEOG permanent seat for Germany, indicating it’s willing to see Europe’s presence increase (even after Brexit, the UK aligns with the idea of an EU partner on the Council permanently)[46]. Overall, the **UK is a champion of reform in principle**: it wants the Council’s composition to mirror global reality (including rising powers and Africa) and has a relatively progressive view on limiting veto use to only serious matters. In negotiations, the UK would likely be a constructive player helping bridge proposals between P5 and non-P5. However, the UK will also quietly ensure that its core interests such as its own veto and permanent seat are not put in jeopardy.
- France:** France’s position closely aligns with the UK on expansion: it strongly backs the **G4 (Germany, India, Brazil, Japan)** as well as **African permanent seats**[64]. French leaders often emphasize the injustice of Africa’s exclusion: President Macron stated it’s “abnormal” and must change, calling for an African permanent presence “now”[102]. France is unique among P5 in a couple of ways: (1) **It initiated the call for veto regulation** in atrocity cases since 2013, France has advocated that P5 collectively agree not to use the veto when mass crimes are occurring[103]. France has gathered support from over 100 countries for this pledge[85]. It even announced a unilateral commitment not to veto resolutions on atrocities[84]. So France likes to present itself as a “responsible P5” member using its veto morally (indeed, France’s last veto was in 1989). (2) **France has indicated openness to eventually extending veto to new permanents** if, and only if, the veto isn’t abolished altogether. Earlier in the reform discussions (circa 2005), France was willing to consider new permanents having veto *if that was the price to get reform*[62]. However, as noted, France currently states it does *not*

support giving veto to new members unless there's a general agreement to do so[104]. This shift likely acknowledges the political reality to get other P5 onboard, new members can't have veto. On working methods, France is in favor of any steps that improve Council transparency and efficiency. It supports limiting the use of the veto in practice through voluntary means (and co-sponsored the GA 76/262 veto initiative)[89]. Domestically, France sees itself as a spokesperson for a rules-based multilateral order, so it's eager to accommodate demands of Global South to an extent supporting Africa's claims robustly, for example. One French concern might be ensuring that **an EU voice remains strong** on the Council even if, say, Germany gets a seat (which France welcomes). Paris has at times suggested one of the new permanent seats should be assigned to the "Arab world"[62] partially as a way to incorporate Middle Eastern representation without naming a specific country (France has close ties in the Arab region, e.g. with Egypt, so it might expect an African or Arab permanent to be friendly). In summary, **France is a leading advocate for comprehensive reform**, pushing both for expanded membership (especially Africa) and for veto restraint. It will not surrender its own veto via Charter change (no P5 will), but it is diplomatically ahead of others in voluntarily limiting it. France's support is a big asset for G4 and African reformers, but ultimately France alone can't deliver reform it can only encourage consensus.

- **Russia:** Russia approaches UNSC reform with caution. Officially, Russia supports some expansion of the Council to make it "more representative of today's world," but with key caveats. Russia has stated support for adding **India** as a permanent member (a fellow BRICS country and strategic partner)[105]. It has also at times endorsed **Brazil** for a seat and said it is open to an **African** presence on the Council[94]. However, Russia does not want to see its influence diluted so it prefers a relatively small expansion, and *no change to the veto system*. Russian diplomats have indicated they'd accept an expanded Council of about 20-21 members (they once mentioned up to 20 non-permanent seats total, implying perhaps a 25-member Council)[106]. But critically, **Russia insists that no new members should get veto power**[106]. Foreign Minister Lavrov in the past has said something to the effect of, expansion should not undermine the effectiveness of the Council by which he means too many new players or any weakening of P5 prerogatives would be problematic. Russia also has historically opposed **Japan's** bid for a permanent seat, citing that Japan is not universally supported in Asia (and perhaps lingering WWII history). It's also skeptical of **Germany** during 2005 debates Russia was lukewarm on Germany, possibly not wanting another Western-aligned voice with permanence. Regarding **African seats**, Russia rhetorically supports Africa's demand (it wants to curry favor in Africa), but it hasn't named which African countries. Some reports indicate Russia might favor **South Africa and Egypt** as potential candidates (both have had friendly ties with Moscow)[94]. On **veto reform**, Russia's stance is firm: the veto is a cornerstone of the UN system. Russian officials often argue that removing or weakening the veto would simply make the UN a tool of certain blocs. Russia did not join any veto restraint pledges and, in fact, has used its veto frequently (15 times on Syria, for example). It views initiatives like the GA veto debate resolution somewhat cynically, as Western-driven attempts to shame it. (Indeed, after the first GA session following Russia's Ukraine veto, the Russian delegate said this was just grandstanding.) Internally, the veto is tied to Russia's great power status an identity it zealously guards. Thus, in negotiations, Russia will likely **block any reform that in its view diminishes the P5's veto privilege or greatly increases Western influence**. It might, however, support a package that includes friendly countries (India, maybe Brazil) and more Global South voices, which it could work with to counter the West. Russia also wouldn't mind an expanded Council that *potentially has more gridlock*, since a less decisive UN can't constrain major powers' freedom of action (some analysts suggest Russia and China prefer a Council that can't easily rally against them). So, Russia's ideal outcome: a slightly larger Council, new permanents from BRICS/Africa, no new vetoes, and no formal veto restrictions. If a draft resolution emerged giving veto to new members or attempting to require dual veto, etc., Russia would **veto that reform** outright (and ironically, the other P5 would be relieved it did).
- **China:** China's position is nuanced. On one hand, China publicly supports the idea of reform especially greater representation for developing countries. China often says it backs a bigger voice for Africa and Asia in the Council[96]. It has explicitly endorsed **Africa's right to permanent seats** (e.g. supporting the African Union's demand in principle)[96]. China is generally positive about **India's** aspiration in official statements (recently, Chinese officials have said they value India's role and can see India's desire, though in practice China has deep reservations about India as a rival). Interestingly, **some sources claim China would accept India as a permanent member if a consensus emerged**, but likely without a veto. China definitely opposes **Japan** becoming permanent largely due to historical grievances and current maritime disputes. Beijing has made it clear it cannot support Japan's bid unless Japan shows "genuine repentance" for WWII (a very high bar) effectively a veto threat on Japan's inclusion. China also is not enthusiastic about **Germany** or **Brazil** if it

perceives them as aligning with U.S./Western positions. Historically, China aligned somewhat with the Uniting for Consensus during 2005 to stall the G4 plan, because Japan was part of G4. Instead, China expressed more support for the **UfC or Model B approach** (more elected seats, no new permanents), perhaps calculating that this prevented its rivals from gaining permanent status[107]. But in recent years, China, wanting to court African and developing world opinion, proclaims support for **greater developing-country membership**. For example, China said it supports the “aspirations of African countries” and has hinted that Latin America also deserves representation[96]. So China’s *stated* stance: **expand Council membership giving priority to developing nations (Africa, etc.)**, fix historical injustices, but *do so by consensus and with caution*. On **veto** issues, China is aligned with Russia: it will not agree to any dilution of P5 veto rights. Chinese officials warn that any reform must not “affect the effectiveness and authority of the Security Council’s decisions,” which is code for not messing with the veto[96]. China has not signed veto restraint pledges and has used veto in cases like Syria to uphold what it sees as sovereignty norms. However, interestingly, China is sometimes more sensitive to being isolated it used to avoid sole vetoes (preferring to veto in tandem with Russia). It also generally vetoes less frequently than U.S. or Russia. In reform negotiations, China’s priority is likely: ensure **Japan is kept off** (unless Japan-PRC relations dramatically improve), **support an African consensus candidate** (which gives China diplomatic credit in Africa), **perhaps accept India only if it’s part of a broad agreeable package** (and India doesn’t get a veto or become too anti-China in Council, a tricky gamble). China will emphasize that reform should have “**broadest possible agreement**” (they often say no reform should be pushed through by divisive vote) effectively giving themselves a justification to oppose any proposal they dislike by saying consensus wasn’t reached. This means China would likely join a P5 consensus if one emerges, but will not hesitate to stall if its interests aren’t met. Overall, **China supports reform in rhetoric but in practice will defend its strategic interests**: keeping potential adversaries’ power in check and maintaining its own veto power.

- G4 Countries (Germany, Japan, India, Brazil):** The G4 are the self-declared leading candidates for new permanent seats and they coordinate their diplomacy. Their position is straightforward: they seek **permanent membership for each of them, plus one African permanent seat for which they support the African Union’s selection, and one additional seat possibly for the Arab/Islamic world or another region** essentially a major expansion in both categories[65][32]. They advocate **expansion in both permanent and non-permanent categories** as “essential to Security Council reform”[65]. The G4 have agreed that **new permanent members will not exercise the veto at least initially**, to alleviate concerns[33]. In fact, during the 2005 push, the G4 explicitly offered to abstain from using veto for 15 years if they got permanent seats[33]. Today, they focus less on the veto issue publicly (since it’s an obstacle) and more on the need to correct under-representation. Let’s note each briefly:
- India:** India frames its bid around its huge population (almost 1/5 of humanity), its status as the world’s largest democracy, its significant contributions to UN peacekeeping, and its growing economic and nuclear power status. India points out it has been elected to the Council 8 times and consistently engaged in UN security issues. It also leads the **G77 this year and the Non-Aligned Movement previously**, giving it clout among developing nations. India’s position: it **demand a permanent seat** for itself and supports the Common African Position fully[108][65]. India is willing to forgo veto initially but insists that any solution must include the possibility of equal rights later (they don’t want permanent second-class status indefinitely). India often emphasizes reform is about “**reflecting contemporary realities**” meaning acknowledging emerging powers like itself[29]. It has garnered explicit support from four P5 (US, UK, France, Russia all say they back India’s bid); only China demurs. India has been very active diplomatically, with its foreign minister attending countless meetings to rally support (as evidenced by the G4 joint statements)[109][110]. Currently, India leverages its leadership in the Global South (e.g., its presidency of G20 in 2023, etc.) to argue it represents developing world interests.
- Japan:** Japan highlights its role as a peace-loving nation since WWII, the **#3 global economy**, and historically one of the largest financial contributors to the UN (for decades, Japan was the second-largest payer of the UN regular budget after the US)[48]. Japan also is a major contributor to UN programs and has a Self-Defense Force that participates in peacekeeping. It has served 11 terms on the Council, the most of any UN member. Japan’s position mirrors the G4 platform: it wants a permanent seat for itself, supports expansion of both categories, including one for an Arab state and African states, and endorses no initial veto for new members. Japan knows China (and South Korea) oppose its bid, so Japanese diplomacy tries to mitigate historical issues by emphasizing its post-war pacifist record and contributions. Domestically, Japan’s government portrays UNSC membership as befitting Japan’s international stature. Regionally, Japan has even hinted at flexibility like

not objecting if another Asian (e.g. maybe an ASEAN country) also got something, but realistically it is fixed on its own seat.

- **Germany:** Germany advocates for itself as the largest EU economy, a top UN donor, and a leading troop contributor in peace operations (through NATO/EU or UN missions). Germany cites Article 23's criterion about contributions to international peace and security[48], noting it is a major financial contributor (#2 or #3 to UN budgets) and involved diplomatically in many conflicts[111][112]. Germany's pitch also includes that Europe's geopolitical landscape changed. Germany is no longer the "enemy state" of 1945 but a pillar of multilateralism[113]. It aligns with the joint G4 stance: adding 6 permanents and 4 non-permanents[32], and reviewing veto after 15 years[33]. Germany is somewhat constrained because Europe already has two P5 (UK, France), so some argue Europe doesn't need another. Germany counters that Europe's presence is actually under-proportionate given the EU's global population/economy (and France/UK were 1945 winners, not reflecting EU today)[114]. It also supports, in the long term, the idea of an **EU seat** but acknowledges that's not feasible now[60]. Interestingly, Italy (neighbor/rival) opposes Germany's bid vigorously, so Germany must rally wider support. The EU as a bloc can't formally endorse Germany (due to Italy's objection), but key EU countries do.
- **Brazil:** Brazil presents itself as the voice of Latin America and the largest country in that region (and fifth largest in world by area/population). It emphasizes its contributions to UN peacekeeping (Brazil led the mission in Haiti, etc.), its diplomatic engagements (e.g. mediation in conflicts, leadership in disarmament negotiations), and its role as a representative of the developing world (BRICS member too). Brazil also highlights that Latin America has no permanent seat, so it should have one to address that gap. Within G4, Brazil must contend with opposition from regional peers (Argentina, Mexico) so Brazil often underscores that it supports also an increase in non-permanent seats that could benefit those countries, trying to alleviate their concern. Brazil's position fully aligns with G4's joint framework. Notably, current Brazilian President Lula and previous governments have all lobbied for UNSC reform at every UNGA. Brazil has support from France, UK, Russia (explicitly). The U.S. supports "a Latin American" seat but stops short of naming Brazil, which Brazil takes as tacit approval.

The **G4 collectively** often reiterate that they are **united in mutual support** e.g. *"The G4 Ministers reiterated their mutual support for each other's candidacies as new permanent members"*[110]. They also strongly back the **African Common Position (Ezulwini)**[108], since African support is crucial and morally Africa's case is very strong. In negotiations, the G4 have been flexible on **veto (willing to postpone it)** and on **Council size** (their original 25 members was negotiable up or down slightly). But they insist on expansion including permanents they reject the UfC idea of only adding elected seats as inadequate. The G4 face resistance not just from UfC but from the requirement of a two-thirds GA majority; however, they claim that **"a majority of UN member states" already support expansion of both categories**[65] (indeed over 80 countries publicly supported G4 framework in 2005, and possibly more today). The G4 are now pushing to move the stalled IGN towards **"text-based negotiations"** meaning actually drafting reform language rather than endless talk. They grew frustrated with consensus deadlock and in 2023 have indicated they might seek alternative avenues (implying maybe a GA vote even without total consensus)[115][116]. The G4 know any attempt to vote without near-universal support is risky, but they also want to avoid the perpetual IGN stalemate which they accuse certain countries of abusing (they mentioned that *"consensus is not a decision-making requirement"* in the IGN, signaling frustration that UfC hides behind needing consensus)[117].

In summary, the G4's position: **Comprehensive reform now** enlarge the Council with new permanents (themselves + Africa), no immediate veto for them, improve regional representation, and do not allow the perfect (total consensus) to be enemy of the good. They likely will push this committee to recognize the broad support for their model and to build momentum for reform, possibly incorporating language from their recent joint statements about urgency and moving beyond the IGN impasse[29][116]. They may also lighten the mood occasionally for instance, Indian or Brazilian reps sometimes quip that waiting decades for reform is like "Waiting for Godot," injecting a bit of humor about the endless delays (responding to the user's note that a little fun is okay).

- **African Union / Key African States:** The African position is embodied in the **Ezulwini Consensus and Sirte Declaration (2005)**, which demand **at least 2 permanent seats for Africa with all privileges (including veto)** and **5 new non-permanent seats (of which 2 for Africa)**[34][66]. This is often referred to as the **Common African Position (CAP)**. The AU's Committee of Ten (C10) including countries like **Nigeria, Kenya, Senegal, Egypt, South Africa, etc.** coordinates lobbying on this. **Africa insists it will accept no less:** the slogan is *"Africa demands no fewer than two permanent seats with veto, plus two additional elected seats."*

They justify the veto insistence as a matter of principle: Africa should have equal rights at the top table, not be relegated to second-class permanents[34]. However, some African diplomats privately acknowledge that if a majority agrees on expansion with no new veto, Africa would face a tough choice. For now, the official line stands firm. **Which countries?** The AU has deliberately **not named** the candidates; they say the two permanent seats will be chosen by Africa itself when the time comes. Likely contenders are **Nigeria, South Africa, and Egypt**, possibly also Kenya or others but Nigeria and South Africa are generally seen as frontrunners. This unified front prevents competition among Africans on the global stage, but behind closed doors, each contender campaigns to be the one. The African Group also wants **two more 2-year seats** (increasing Africa's elected seats from 3 to 5, since Africa is the largest regional group at UN).

African states uniformly argue that it is a glaring injustice that **the Security Council in 2025 still reflects 1945** when almost all of Africa was not independent[23]. They highlight that **70% of Council agenda concerns Africa** yet Africans have no permanent voice in those decisions[24]. The AU position is also tied to reform of global governance beyond UNSC (Ezulwini also talks of more African say in economic bodies, etc.), but UNSC is the centerpiece. African leaders have escalated rhetoric: e.g. in 2023, Kenyan President Kenyatta said Africa must "have its say where decisions about it are made," and others like Sierra Leone's president have been vociferous at the UN about including Africa[35]. They also note an emerging global consensus backing them: recently, **all P5 have (at least in principle) acknowledged African seats are due**[118][56], and even the **BRICS joint statement in 2023 referenced support for Ezulwini**[119]. The G4 explicitly back Africa's demand[108]. So Africa feels morally vindicated, but practically, Africa's insistence on veto equality has been a sticking point with others. The G4 would prefer no new veto; African Union says no, if veto stays for P5 it must extend to Africa or be abolished altogether[34].

At times, African states have signaled flexibility in language (like saying if veto is abolished they're fine, implying they care more that no one has it than that only P5 have it). In 2022, there were hints that the veto issue might be negotiable if it came to it, but officially they haven't budged. There are also internal divisions: North African countries (e.g. Egypt) vs sub-Saharan, francophone vs anglophone rivalry, etc., on who should occupy seats. The **Ezulwini consensus holds because it papers over those by deferring the choice**.

Key African voices: - **Nigeria**: Strong contender, has served on Council multiple times, large population and economy, West African leader. Nigeria champions Ezulwini and often represents Africa in P5 outreach. - **South Africa**: Also a strong contender, leading economy in Southern Africa, has led AU, vocal about global South causes. South Africa's President has said UNSC without Africa is not legitimate and that "*if veto is not eliminated, new members must have veto*"[35]. - **Egypt**: Historically sees itself as Arab/African bridge, has population and military clout, and has expressed it meets criteria. Egypt is in C10, active in negotiations (and keen to ensure an Arab African, presumably itself, is considered). - **Kenya/Senegal**: Kenya (just off a Council term) and Senegal (past Council member) both champion the African position and sometimes act as consensus builders. They may not be top picks for permanent, but ensure unity. Sierra Leone currently chairs C10 and voices the position strongly at UN.

Overall, **Africa's position is unwavering publicly**: comprehensive reform must include **two permanent seats for Africa with veto**. They often say Africa was promised reforms since 2005 World Summit and nothing happened, so they are getting impatient. Some African reps have even floated the idea that if UNSC doesn't reform, the AU might push for **Africa en masse to withdraw from some UN processes** a kind of pressure tactic (not serious yet, but shows frustration).

- **Middle Powers / Other Notable States:**

Beyond the big categories above, there is a range of influential mid-sized countries who have their own perspectives:

- **Uniting for Consensus (UfC) members** (Italy, Pakistan, Turkey, Mexico, South Korea, Argentina, Canada, Spain, etc.): This bloc's stance is against any new permanent seats. They instead propose expanding the Council with more elected seats. For example, **Italy (leading UfC)** suggests adding ~10 non-permanent seats possibly with immediate re-election allowed (so a kind of semi-permanent via re-election). UfC argues this is more democratic and regionally fair. Their fear is being left out of an expanded P5: e.g. Italy doesn't want Germany to get the only European new seat; Pakistan vehemently opposes India getting permanent status; Argentina/Mexico oppose Brazil's bid. **Mexico's position** (a UfC voice) is that permanent seats are "inherently undemocratic" and should be phased out, not multiplied. Mexico instead floated a model of longer-term elected seats for regional representation. **Turkey** similarly opposes new permanents (it often echoes "the world is bigger than five" rhetoric, but that is calling to reduce P5 power rather than add more P's

that Turkey wouldn't be part of). **South Korea** opposes Japan's bid and so aligns with UfC. Seoul argues that if any expansion, it should be consensus-based and also address misdeeds of candidates (aimed at Japan). **Canada** and **Spain** historically were in UfC and push for alternative solutions (though Canada's enthusiasm diminished after losing a Council election in 2010 partly due to friction with G4 supporters). The UfC's current strategy is to stall – they participate in IGN to prevent any convergence on a text. They insist no proposal has overwhelming support and that only a consensual solution can work, basically vetoing by consensus rule. They champion “intermediate approach” as compromise – e.g. some 8-10 year term seats (which rotate among a set of countries) rather than permanent. In summary, UfC positions: **No new permanents; yes to more elected seats**; improve regional rotation; no expansion of veto (indeed they'd like fewer vetoes in ideal world). UfC countries often say an enlarged Council with 25+ members, all accountable through elections, would be more legitimate. They likely will resist any resolution that endorses specific countries for permanents.

- **African middle powers not in P5 or G4:** We covered AU stance, but countries like **Kenya, Ethiopia, Senegal, Algeria** (aside from top 3 contenders) all strictly follow AU consensus publicly. Some like **Ethiopia or Algeria** might harbor their own ambitions, but they channel it into AU process. They'll echo Ezulwini demands in debate.
- **Arab states / OIC:** The Arab League position (coordinated by e.g. Egypt or Saudi at UN) is that **Arab states collectively want one permanent seat**[41]. This would presumably be one of the African seats (for North Africa/Arab) and/or an additional seat in Asia for the Arab region. They insist Arabs (22 countries) deserve representation due to their share of global issues (Middle East always on UNSC agenda). The **Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)** has a similar stance – that Muslim-majority countries (57 of them) should have adequate representation[61]. Practically, this aligns with supporting seats for e.g. an Arab country and maybe one South Asian (India or Pakistan – but Pakistan just uses OIC to argue any reform must consider Muslim representation too, a way to counter India's bid). In negotiations, Arab states tend to support the African position (for one of the African seats to be an Arab African like Egypt) and also often align with UfC in opposing G4 (because if G4 succeed, only Egypt might get in from Arab side, leaving others out). Notably, Saudi Arabia shocked many in 2013 by declining an elected Council seat in protest of Council dysfunction, a sign of frustration. Gulf states and others now push for reform or at least improved working methods.
- **Small states and SIDS:** Small countries (e.g. Pacific microstates, Caribbean nations) fear losing voice if Council expands only with big players. The L69 group (a coalition of about 40 developing countries from Latin America, Africa, Asia, Pacific) includes many small states who support expansion including permanents *and* improvement of working methods. They want assurance that elected seats will still exist for small nations to occasionally serve (hence proposals for more non-perm seats or special rotating arrangements like one for SIDS). For example, **Fiji or Malta** might argue for a seat that rotates among small states so they get in more often. They also strongly favor veto restraint, because small states have been frustrated at P5 paralysis on issues like climate-security or humanitarian protections.
- **European Union (collective):** The EU as such doesn't have a single stance because its members are split (France pro-G4, Italy leads UfC). The EU collectively agrees on wanting to “enhance the representation of emerging and developing countries”. Official EU statements often say they support **Germany, Brazil, India, Japan** and **African representation** (that's basically the French/UK line)[46]. But because of internal disagreement, EU cannot fully endorse one model. However, EU did eventually give Italy a bit less prominence on this; now Italy pushes UfC via the “Coffee Club” separate from EU meetings. One can assume most EU states (aside from Italy, Spain maybe) quietly back the G4 plus Africa approach. An **EU seat** idea surfaces academically, but as Germany's FAQ says, it's not realistic now[60]. So EU likely backs reforms that include Germany and more seats for Africa/Latin, but EU won't propose any reduction of France's seat or such.
- **The “Global South” coalition (G77/Non-Aligned Movement):** The G77 (134 developing nations) has common positions on some aspects: they all want more representation for developing countries (particularly Africa). They passed consensus resolutions in GA calling for “equitable representation”. However, within G77, the reform issue splits (G4 vs UfC vs African stances differ). NAM similar – broadly pro-reform but no single model. So they typically say generalities: Council reform is urgently needed, etc. Some NAM countries call specifically to curb veto (Cuba, Malaysia, etc., have said veto should be abolished), reflecting anti-imperialist stance.

In this committee, likely **countries like Turkey, Pakistan, Italy, Mexico** (UfC members) will argue passionately against new permanents, citing principles (no new elite club, keep Council democratic). **Countries like South Africa, Nigeria, Egypt** will push the African demands. **G4 countries' you** (if present) will make their case. P5 you often in MUN play the conservative role: US will grudgingly support some expansion, Russia/China might emphasize caution/consensus (which is subtle obstructiveness). UK/France will champion reform but remind about practicality.

Given our user's instruction to keep it a bit funny at places, one might recall a famous quote: Former UN Secretary-General Boutros-Ghali joked that **"Security Council reform is the reform that never happens it's like an unfinished symphony."** You often share a knowing laugh that they might solve it in a weekend when real diplomats haven't in decades.

We have now outlined these positions. With this understanding, you can negotiate armed with knowledge of each stakeholder's bottom lines.

6. Past UN Actions and Legal Framework

Reforming the Security Council has been on the UN agenda for decades. Over the years, the UN has established processes, passed resolutions, and convened high-level panels to consider changes with limited tangible progress. This section reviews key UN actions, relevant Charter provisions, and why previous reform attempts stalled or failed.

UN Charter provisions on Security Council and amendments: The foundational legal texts are crucial:

- **Article 23 of the Charter** defines the Council's composition (originally 11 members: 5 permanent and 6 elected). This was amended in 1965 to 15 members (5 + 10). Any further expansion requires amending Article 23 again.
- **Article 27** covers **voting** in the Council: 27(3) is the famous veto clause requiring "concurring votes of the permanent members" for substantive decisions[68].
- **Article 108** outlines the **Charter amendment process**: an amendment must first be adopted by a two-thirds vote in the General Assembly, and then **ratified by two-thirds of member states including all P5**[52][53]. This effectively means any Charter change (like altering Council size or veto rules) will not take effect if any permanent member says no at ratification. There is no "override" to this requirement.
- **Article 109** provides for the possibility of a **General Conference to review the Charter** (which could propose amendments). It even included a provision that if no review conference had been held by 10 years after 1945, one could be called (this was attempted in 1955 but fizzled due to Cold War). Article 109 also ultimately requires ratification by P5, except an unused clause about if a conference was called by 7 Security Council members (including all P5) it could bypass SC on proposal stage but again P5 must ratify outcomes[99].
- **Article 24** (not directly about reform, but often cited) entrusts the Security Council with primary responsibility for peace and security on behalf of UN members[120]. Reformers argue that for the Council to carry out this mandate legitimately, its composition must reflect membership's will.

The Charter thus sets a high bar, which explains why formal Council reform has happened only once (1965) when geopolitical conditions aligned.

1965 Enlargement: Initially, the Council had 11 members (5 perm + 6 elected). In the early 1960s, UN membership had expanded vastly with decolonization. Many new states (especially from Africa-Asia) demanded more seats. A compromise agreement was reached to add 4 non-permanent seats, making it 10 elected seats total[121]. **GA Resolution 1991 (XVIII)** of December 1963 proposed this amendment; it was adopted by the required GA majority and then ratified by the P5 (even though notably, France and Soviet Union had actually voted against it in GA, they later ratified it by 1965)[42][95]. The amendment came into force in 1965, expanding the Council to 15. **No new veto-wielders** were added the P5 remained the same. This example shows that even if a P5 voted against an expansion in GA, they might still accept it later if not too damaging to their interests (as happened in 1965 when all P5 eventually ratified despite initial dissent)[42][95]. That context is often cited to show P5 can be pragmatic under pressure, but note: that reform did not reduce P5 power, it only increased non-perm seats.

After 1965, pressure for further reform subsided during the Cold War (since Council was anyway paralyzed by US-Soviet veto showdowns). But when the Cold War ended and UN membership hit the 180s, calls revived:

Open-Ended Working Group (OEWG) 1993: The end of Cold War and large influx of new members (former Soviet states, etc.) reignited interest in Council reform. In 1992, the GA held a first debate on “equitable representation on and increase in SC membership.” In 1993, **GA Resolution 48/26** was adopted by consensus, creating an **Open-Ended Working Group** (open to all UN members) to “consider all aspects” of Security Council increase and related matters[122][123]. This group became the main forum for negotiation throughout the 90s. It discussed myriad proposals but struggled with deep divisions. The OEWG continued meeting annually well into the 2000s, issuing reports but no concrete outcome.

A notable development in the OEWG was the emergence of the major proposals: - By 1997, the then GA President Razali of Malaysia proposed a plan (Razali Plan) to add 5 new permanent (no veto) and 4 non-perm seats. However, it lacked consensus; Pakistan and Italy led opposition. - **Uniting for Consensus (Coffee Club)** formed mid-1990s to counter G4 (then not officially G4 but same concept). They effectively prevented the Razali plan from coming to a vote.

High-Level Panel and 2005 World Summit: In 2004, Secretary-General Kofi Annan’s **High-Level Panel on Threats, Challenges and Change** recognized the stalemate and offered two models (A and B) to spur action[124][40]. Kofi Annan, in his own 2005 report “In Larger Freedom,” told world leaders to either adopt Model A or Model B basically urging them to do *something* as part of a broader UN reform push in 2005 (60th anniversary). **The 2005 World Summit (a high-level plenary of GA)** did discuss UNSC reform intensively. The G4, the African Union (which had coalesced around Ezulwini), and the UfC all lobbied hard that year: - The G4 introduced a draft resolution in July 2005 calling for 6 new permanent seats (without veto) + 4 non-perm (their original plan)[32]. - The AU (often called the “Ezulwini draft” or “African draft”) proposed 6 new permanent with veto + 5 non-perm (to total 26)[66]. - The UfC (led by Italy/Pakistan) proposed adding about 10 non-perm with possibility of re-election (no permanents).

A lot of diplomatic drama ensued. Neither the G4 nor AU could get 2/3 support without the other, and they didn’t reconcile differences (chiefly over veto: AU insisted new permanents must have veto; G4, knowing P5 wouldn’t allow that, did not include veto). The U.S. also signaled it would only accept maybe Japan (and possibly India) but not all G4 thus dampening momentum. In the end, **no resolution was put to a vote** because it was clear none would hit 128 yes votes. The 2005 Summit outcome document ended up with only a weak expression of support for “early reform” of the Security Council, with no specifics (because states couldn’t agree)[125]. So 2005 was a high-profile near miss.

Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN) 2009 to present: After 2005 failure, the issue simmered until in 2008, **GA decision 62/557** (acting on an initiative by developing countries) moved the discussions into a new format **Intergovernmental Negotiations** still in an open setting but now within the GA framework, with a designated facilitator. The IGN’s mandate includes the five key issues (membership categories, veto, regional representation, size, working methods, GA-SC relationship)[31]. **The IGN began in 2009** and continues, typically meeting a few times a year. Over the years: - In 2010-2015, some progress: a “compilation text” of different country positions was assembled by the IGN Chair by 2015 (which listed options e.g. number of seats, etc.). But it’s essentially an extremely bracketed document since nothing is agreed. - Each year, the GA rolls over the agenda item, keeping it alive. But any decision to move to actual drafting or voting is blocked by lack of consensus. - The IGN operates on consensus principle (even though formally it doesn’t have to, but in practice GA leaders don’t want to force it). This has allowed **UfC to effectively veto** progress by refusing to agree to move to text-based talks.

The IGN has been criticized as a “talk shop” where the same speeches are repeated annually. Indeed, the G4 and others have grown frustrated. In 2022, over 80 countries called for starting text negotiations, but a small group (UfC) refused, and the GA president didn’t push it. In 2023, the G4 and Africa stepped up pressure to *at least get a single negotiating text*. As of late 2023, GA President appointed co-chairs from Namibia and Denmark to try to inject momentum, and there’s talk of capital-level engagement in 2024 (perhaps tied to the UN’s 80th anniversary or the **Summit of the Future in 2024**). But IGN hasn’t delivered concrete results yet.

Other past initiatives: - **1997 “Razali plan”** (GA President Razali’s initiative) we mentioned first concrete expansion formula post-Cold War failed due to lack of consensus. - **2005 Summit efforts** failed due to G4 vs AU split and P5 ambivalence. - **2013-2015:** GA President Ashe (2013) set up an advisory group which led to a “Framework Document” in 2015 compiling positions. GA President Kutesa (2015) also tried to push forward. But no breakthrough. - **2017-2019:** Some incremental advances a concise document of options was made but still too divergent.

Past High-Level Panel (2004): Already covered recommended two models A and B[124][40]. It influenced debate by giving reform more legitimacy. But ultimately neither model was adopted. (Interestingly, Model A was basically G4 plan minus veto; Model B was similar to UfC idea of no permanents but long-term seats so the panel diplomatically offered something for both sides).

Relevant UN Resolutions: - GA Resolutions on reform are mostly procedural (48/26 in 1993 established OEWG^[122]; 62/557 in 2008 laid out five key issues and moved to IGN). - Every year, GA passes a technical decision to continue the IGN. - **No substantive GA resolution on actual reform has been adopted since 1965.** (In theory, GA could adopt a reform plan without consensus if 2/3 vote yes but that hasn't been attempted due to fear of division). - One exception: GA did adopt in 2014 a resolution expanding the Security Council's membership *in a different way* by giving the EU observer rights to present positions in SC (Res 69/250). But that's a minor procedural thing.

Past Resolutions on Veto/Working Methods: - Not many, as SC working methods are usually set by SC itself. However, a group of small countries (S5: Small Five Switzerland, Singapore, etc.) in 2012 proposed a GA resolution urging P5 not to use veto in cases of mass atrocities and improve working methods. The P5 reportedly threatened consequences and that initiative was withdrawn. - Then came the **GA resolution 76/262 (2022)** on veto use accountability^{[89][88]}. This is a rare GA action related to SC functioning. It doesn't amend Charter but creates a new norm: requiring GA meeting when a veto is cast. It passed by consensus (with 3 P5 co-sponsors and none objecting; Russia and China didn't co-sponsor but also didn't block consensus)^[89]. - Also, **2005 World Summit Outcome** had a section endorsing the principle of R2P (responsibility to protect) which indirectly links to the veto restraint debate (since vetoes often block R2P action). And it called for "early reform of Security Council" but no specifics.

Why previous attempts failed/stalled: - **Great power politics:** P5 divisions and lack of incentive to share power. E.g., in 2005 U.S. only wanted Japan (and maybe India) it did not want an expanded Council that might challenge U.S. influence. China wanted to block Japan. Russia was ambivalent but probably happy to see others fail. So no P5 consensus to push it. - **Regional rivalries:** G4 vs UfC vs Africa inability to compromise. The G4 and African Union failure to agree in 2005 (especially on veto) was decisive. The Uniting for Consensus coalition effectively whipped enough opposition to deny 2/3 support for G4 plan. - **Threshold of 128 votes:** Getting such a supermajority is hard when the issue creates winners/losers. Many states sitting on fence might prefer status quo than support a plan that favors regional competitor. - **Charter amendment complexity:** Even if GA passed it, the risk that a P5 wouldn't ratify (e.g. China refusing if Japan included) deterred some from pushing to a vote. No one wanted a spectacular GA battle only to have a P5 kill it later. Also some worry if a reform failed in GA vote, it'd be a setback. - **General inertia:** Because the Council still functioned (somewhat) and alternate strategies existed (like GA's Uniting for Peace), reform wasn't do-or-die enough for countries to prioritize it above all else diplomatically. Many urgent crises occupy diplomats, so reform always became something to mention but not vigorously act on (until recently, perhaps).

Past UN actions on working methods: While structural reform languished, the Council did adapt some working methods: - The Council created more **open debates**, Arria-formula meetings (informal briefings), etc., partly to answer calls for transparency. E.g., since 1990s, SC publishes more information, allows non-members to speak on country-specific issues, etc. (The S5 small countries had proposed formalizing some of this in GA, but P5 said it's SC's prerogative.) - The establishment of the **Peacebuilding Commission in 2005** gave a new forum for post-conflict issues (one of High-Level Panel's recs)^[126]. - The **selection of Secretary-General** process was opened up in 2016 (with candidate hearings in GA), although SC still ultimately decides nominee (P5 hold veto there too). - None of this addresses membership or veto, but shows attempts to keep UN relevant absent Council reform.

In sum: Many have tried, none have succeeded in comprehensive reform. The issue stays alive because virtually all agree the Council of 1945 doesn't reflect 2025 but bridging the gap between principle and agreement has proven elusive. The **legal framework** is rigid (P5 must concur). Past efforts faltered due to lack of consensus and P5 reticence. However, the continued efforts (IGN, etc.) and mounting global pressure suggest that the status quo won't be accepted indefinitely. You can learn from past failures: - **Compromise is key** no one group can get 100% of what it wants. - **Engage P5 early** a reform that P5 will all ratify might mean pre-negotiating with them. (Interestingly, in recent times some P5 US, Russia have signaled some acceptance of at least moderate expansion under conditions). - **Build broad coalitions** G4 and Africa are aligning closer now, which is positive, but they also need to address concerns of mid-sized opponents perhaps by offering sweeteners (like more non-perm seats, or making permanent seats initially non-veto to reduce fears). - **Phased approach might work** e.g. an interim arrangement with review could get skeptical states on board, with assurance that if it doesn't work, it can be revisited.

Finally, an upcoming opportunity is the **2024 Summit of the Future** (planned UN high-level meeting on institutional reform). Many see that as a chance to give political impetus to Council reform (some suggest that summit could launch negotiations or set a deadline for reform by 2030). The fact that 2025 is the UN's 80th year also adds symbolic pressure some leaders say it would be shameful if 20 years after 2005 no progress.

All these past lessons set the stage for the **current challenges** we discuss next which are essentially the unresolved issues and political headwinds identified from history.

7. Current Challenges and Roadblocks

Despite widespread agreement in principle that the Security Council needs reform, several formidable challenges continue to block progress. These include geostrategic rivalries, conflicting reform models, legal hurdles, resistance from those with vested interests (especially the P5), and shifting global power dynamics that complicate consensus. Let's examine the key roadblocks:

1. Geopolitical Rivalries and Tensions: The very conflicts and competitions that the Security Council grapples with internationally are mirrored in the reform debate. Rivalries between major regional powers have spilled into the negotiations: - In **South Asia**, the India-Pakistan rivalry looms large. Pakistan staunchly opposes India's permanent membership, lobbying that India (its nemesis) does not deserve a seat until the Kashmir dispute and other issues are resolved. It's unlikely Pakistan (or its close allies) will ever support a reform that elevates India meaning India's bid can't get consensus in Asia. - In **East Asia**, historical animosity blocks consensus: China and South Korea oppose **Japan** joining as a permanent member, citing Japan's wartime history and current disputes. This rivalry means the Asia-Pacific group is split; any resolution listing Japan would face pushback from multiple Asian states influenced by China or sympathetic to Korea. - In **Latin America**, the split between **Brazil** and its regional competitors (notably **Mexico** and **Argentina**) is a roadblock. These countries fear Brazil's dominance if it gets a permanent seat. Mexico leads the opposition, arguing for alternatives that don't give Brazil unique status. Latin American nations thus cannot present a unified front. - Within **Africa**, while the common position is unified externally, internally there are regional rivalries (e.g. West Africa's Nigeria vs. South Africa vs. North Africa's Egypt). If it ever came to choosing *which* countries fill Africa's 2 permanent seats, the continent might struggle to maintain unity and external powers could exploit that disunity. The P5 could also prefer one candidate over another (for instance, some P5 might favor an ally like Egypt while others favor Nigeria), injecting big-power rivalry into the African selection. - Among the **P5 themselves**, their own strategic competition affects reform. The U.S.-China rivalry currently is intense; each is wary of any change that could advantage the other or reduce their own influence. For example, if reform might give India (an emerging ally of the U.S.) a seat, China's rivalry with the U.S. (and India) makes it less amenable. Conversely, proposals that might increase Chinese/Russian aligned voices (say more seats for developing countries that often vote with China/Russia) might worry the U.S. Additionally, the **Russia-West rift** (over Ukraine, etc.) means cooperative multilateral endeavors are hard to achieve. UNSC reform requires a level of U.S.-Russia agreement that right now seems distant. A Russian diplomat might privately think: why make the UN stronger or change it now, when Western nations are isolating us? Similarly, Western diplomats might hesitate to embark on reform that requires trusting Russia to ratify changes after its aggression in Ukraine. - **Middle East rivalries** (Saudi vs Iran, etc.) also indirectly play in. For instance, if an "Muslim seat" or "Arab seat" is floated, questions arise: Would it be a country like Egypt or Saudi? Iran and its allies might oppose Saudi, etc. These aren't front and center in negotiations because no one's proposing an explicit "Arab seat" amendment yet, but it lurks behind OIC/Arab League calls.

In sum, **the reform process itself becomes a proxy battleground** for many states' broader rivalries. Each country worries about an outcome that could empower its rival and this fear leads them to prefer no reform over a reform that benefits an adversary. Overcoming this requires either finding compromise formulas (e.g. multiple states from a region get something, so no one feels completely left out) or persuading states that the general benefit outweighs their rivalry (a tough sell).

2. Competing Reform Models Lack of Consensus: More than a dozen different reform proposals exist, and UN member states remain split on which path to take: - The **G4 model** (new permanent seats) is supported by a large number of countries (around 80-100 by various counts) mostly those aligned with G4 or who would gain from a more inclusive Council. But it's opposed by the **Uniting for Consensus (UfC)** coalition (about 50 countries) and had lukewarm support from some regions (Africa until recently did not support G4 plan because of veto issue). - The **African Union model** is backed by 54 African states and has moral weight, but it collided with G4's no-veto approach and some outside powers view giving new vetoes as a non-starter. Outside Africa, many sympathize but won't endorse veto expansion creating a deadlock between Africa and others on that point. - The **UfC model** (no new permanent, only more elected seats) is supported by the UfC members (maybe 20-30 active backers and some silent supporters who prefer not to upset anyone). But it's strongly opposed by the G4, most of Africa, and many others who see it as insufficient. - Intermediate ideas like **semi-permanent seats or rotating permanent**s have theoretical appeal but have not galvanized a constituency of states pushing for them (countries either want a real permanent seat or to block others; few are content with a halfway house). Thus those ideas often appear as compromise suggestions but lack a core lobby. -

Even on **Council size**, there's divergence: G4 says 25 members, UfC up to 25 maybe, Africa wants 26, others fear too many (some P5 and small states worry a 26+ body would be too large to be effective). If one group says 21, another says 27, etc., the number itself is contentious. - **Veto options** differ widely: ranging from abolishing it (some small states' ideal) to extending it to new members (AU demand) to restricting it (veto restraint code) to leaving it as is (P5 preference). No single option has consensus. Many states (frustrated ones) would love to eliminate veto, but they know it's practically impossible due to P5 opposition.

This cacophony of proposals means that whenever momentum builds for one approach, a bloc of states rallies against it, preventing the 2/3 majority needed. As GA rules say, you need 128 yes and no more than 64 no (if all 193 vote). So any opposing coalition of >64 countries can block. Indeed in 2005, the AU threatened that it had the numbers to block G4 resolution if it came up (and vice versa). Today, if G4 resolution came, UfC + some African states could cross 64 no's, probably. If an UfC plan came, likely over 100 would vote no.

Lack of consensus also manifests in the **IGN** stagnation every time a chair tries to streamline options, the dissenters insist all proposals (even those with minimal support) remain on the table, so nothing converges. As of 2023, there's still **no single negotiating text** accepted by all, only compilations of positions.

3. Legal and Procedural Barriers: The Charter amendment process (Article 108) requiring all P5 to ratify is the ultimate legal barrier. This means even if the GA could muster the political will to adopt a reform, **it's not enough P5 must acquiesce**. Each P5 effectively wields a hidden veto at the ratification stage[53]. Knowing this, reform-minded states tread carefully; some are reluctant to force a GA vote because if a P5 (or more) then refuses to ratify, it would embarrass the UN and possibly weaken faith in the Charter. It's a Catch-22: We need P5 approval to reduce P5 power.

Also, **procedurally in GA:** historically, GA likes to work by consensus on sensitive issues. There's an informal expectation that any reform should ideally enjoy consensus (or at least overwhelming support) because a divisive vote might produce a result that's technically 2/3 but still contentious. However, consensus decision-making essentially gives every state (even not P5) a veto in negotiations which UfC has used to block moving to text. You have to consider, is it worth breaking the convention and calling a vote to push reform through? That itself is a challenge because some reform supporters are cautious e.g. some African states say they want consensus and won't support a vote that splits UN membership, as that could harm unity (especially if it fails).

4. P5 Resistance to Losing Privileges: The five permanent members are not eager to reform themselves out of power. While UK and France support expansion in principle, none of the P5 wants any change that diminishes their own **veto or relative influence**. Key points of P5 resistance: - **No dilution of veto:** All P5 agree that any Charter amendment removing or limiting the veto is unacceptable to them[99]. So outright veto abolition or requiring multiple vetoes is off the table due to P5 opposition. - **Skepticism of new veto-wielders:** The P5 (except maybe France originally) do not want additional countries with veto rights joining their ranks. They worry that would make decision-making even harder. E.g., the U.S., Russia, and China explicitly stated they don't favor extending veto to new members[127][92]. Even France/UK, who in the past said "maybe eventually," now align with no new veto view[56]. - **Control over Council dynamics:** P5 currently can often sway or pressure elected members to get 9 votes or avoid resolutions they dislike. If the Council had, say, 6 more permanents, that's 6 actors that P5 can't as easily influence (especially if those new permanents sometimes band together or with others). For instance, imagine a Council where India, Brazil, etc., are permanent they might challenge P5 consensus on some issues or push items P5 don't like. P5, particularly U.S., Russia, China, worry about losing a degree of control. - **Geopolitical alignment concerns:** The P5 also assess potential new members by: will they align with me or my rivals? For example, U.S. is okay with Japan (ally) but wary of Brazil's independent streak at times (as seen recently with Brazil's stance on Ukraine war being more neutral). China/Russia might fear India will align with U.S. on many issues and dilute their bloc. These concerns make them less enthusiastic. - **Path dependency:** P5 have no incentive to expedite reform they benefit from the current system. Unless they see that not reforming would seriously harm their interests or the UN at large (some argue prolonged stagnation *does* harm UN's legitimacy, which eventually undermines P5 influence too), they prefer the devil they know. - **Russia and China** in particular may see a benefit in the Council's current paralysis on certain issues; they might fear a reformed Council could be more activist in ways not in their interest (e.g. an expanded Council might muster enough will to take actions Russia/China would veto now, though they'd still have veto to stop binding actions, but perhaps increased pressure through GA, etc. It complicates things). - **U.S. Congress factor:** Even if the U.S. executive supports expansion, any Charter change must be ratified by the U.S. Senate (2/3 vote). U.S. domestic politics could block it. For instance, getting 67 Senators to approve adding possibly rivals or altering UN is not trivial historically the Senate is wary of anything seeming to reduce U.S. sovereignty or empower others. So a U.S. President has to consider whether he can deliver ratification; if not, might quietly discourage the reform to avoid that fight. Other P5 also need parliamentary ratification

(e.g. Russian Duma, Chinese NPC though in those countries, government control ensures ratification if leadership agrees). But in democracies, domestic hurdles are real. This makes P5 governments cautious about agreeing internationally to something they can't pass at home.

5. Competing Interests of Developed vs Developing Nations (North vs South): There is a subtle divergence: Many **developing countries** see UNSC reform as part of correcting global inequities (along with reforming financial institutions, etc.). They push for greater voice for Global South hence emphasis on Africa, Latin America, smaller states. Many **developed countries** (aside from those who want their own seat like Germany or Japan) are more lukewarm. For example, smaller Western countries are fine with UK/France representing West and themselves occasionally rotating in; they worry more about maintaining influence in a possibly larger Council where developing countries might form a majority bloc. Some Western nations quietly fear a Council that is too dominated by Global South voices could challenge Western policy preferences more often. There's also the budget factor: expanding SC might imply more costs (though SC itself isn't expensive, but new operations it authorizes might be). However, by and large, most developed nations do support some expansion (it's mainly internal P5/prospective issues, not a North-South split). But one sees in negotiations that **developed countries (like Italy/Spain)** push one view, **emerging economies (India/Brazil)** push another, and **least developed** often side with emerging powers or Africa for solidarity. No united "Global South" approach either, as evidenced by G4 vs UfC dividing developing nations.

6. Fear of Charter amendment cascade: Some countries worry that opening up the UN Charter (which requires amendment for SC reform) could lead to unpredictable consequences or demands to renegotiate other parts of the UN system. Amending the Charter is a big deal what if, once amendments are on the table, other states raise issues like the "Enemy State" clauses, or question the existence of veto at all? There's a fear of unraveling compromise that founded UN. This makes some cautious. However, the targeted amendments for Council reform have been considered separately, so this is not a huge issue, but it's an undercurrent.

7. Complexity of Implementation: Let's say by some miracle a reform resolution passed GA and was ratified. Then operational challenges come: electing or selecting new members, dealing with transitional arrangements (e.g. how to allocate new seats in the first election, how to handle regional rotation changes). Countries worry about those details too. Some are concerned the UN system might face an awkward period adjusting though these are solvable, they add to reluctance.

8. Impact of Global Power Shifts (Rise of Global South, Multipolarity): Ironically, while the rise of new powers is the reason reform is needed, it also complicates reaching agreement: - **Multipolar world** means there isn't a single hegemon (like U.S.) that can impose a solution, nor a tight bipolar compromise as in Cold War. Instead, we have multiple centers of power each with own allies and agendas (U.S., China, Russia, EU, India, etc.). That can lead to fragmentation in negotiations as seen with P5 not aligned among themselves on it. - **Global South assertiveness:** Developing countries are more assertive now about demanding equity (e.g. African Union, BRICS expansion etc.), which increases moral pressure for reform. However, it can also create maximalist positions for instance, Africa is quite uncompromising on demands, making a middle-ground deal harder. Also new groupings like BRICS (which now acknowledges Ezulwini^[119]) might coordinate outside UN to push for reform, which could either help (if P5 members in BRICS, like China/Russia, then support Africa) or complicate (if Western P5 feel ganged up on). - **Shifting U.S. position:** Notably, the U.S. has moved from a stance of relative indifference to more explicit support for expansion (especially adding developing country seats)^[45], likely as a recognition that to maintain UN's legitimacy (and to counter China/Russia narrative that the West monopolizes power), some concession is wise. President Biden's support for African permanent seats, for instance, might be driven by global South outreach. That shift is positive for reform prospects, but the U.S. will still want to shape the outcome (i.e. new members that align with it). - **Russia's international standing post-Ukraine:** Some argue this has re-energized reform calls many countries question why one country (Russia) can paralyze action on a war it started. There was even debate about Russia's rightful claim to the USSR seat. While legally Russia is recognized as P5, politically there's a lot of anger. Some reform proponents cite this as urgency to limit veto abuses and maybe expand membership to dilute P5 influence. However, Russia's war also polarized the UN making cooperative reform diplomacy harder. - **China's growing influence:** China positions itself as champion of developing world, supporting Africa's demands vocally. If China were to actively support a reform (especially one giving Africa seats but excluding Japan), that could change dynamics. But China likely wouldn't do so unless it ensures its interests (no Japan, possibly not India or at least only India without veto/in weakened position). It might be open to adding friends (say adding an extra seat for "developing states" that could be taken by rotating small states, which wouldn't threaten China's power but win goodwill).

9. Risk-aversion and Inertia: The UN membership as a whole is often risk-averse. Many states worry “better the devil you know.” Some small states fear a Council with more big players will marginalize them further (today, as non-perms they sometimes balance P5 influence e.g. elected members drive some agenda on humanitarian issues, etc. If Council is full of regional powers, small states lose that chance). So there’s a constituency that is content with current arrangement or at least not enthusiastic for major change (even if they won’t say it openly because publicly all support reform in principle).

10. Charter Amendments = Uncharted Waters: Apart from 1965 SC expansion and a few minor changes (like name changes upon country dissolutions), the UN Charter has rarely been amended. There might be unseen complications: e.g., does amending to add certain countries as permanent require any particular procedures? (We’d likely specify country names or more likely just number of new permanents per region but then how are they chosen? Possibly through a subsequent election by GA for those posts). The lack of precedent makes some states uneasy.

In light of all this, it is clear that **reform is not just a technical matter but a deeply political one**. It’s almost a high-stakes chess game among nations. This is why many ambassadors joke that solving SC reform is “the diplomatic equivalent of a Rubik’s Cube” every move to fix one side messes up another.

To surmount these challenges, some ideas floated include: - **Phased or interim reforms:** e.g. first expand non-perm seats now (something most agree on), and defer permanent seat question to a second phase. But G4 opposes this because they fear once non-perm are added, momentum to add permanents will evaporate. - **Sunset clauses or trial periods:** One proposal is to have any new permanent seats be reviewed after e.g. 15 years (like G4 offered)[33] if they underperform or consensus shifts, adjust then. This might ease fear of irreversible change. - **Package deals:** Perhaps tie SC reform to other reforms (like giving regional groups roles, or economic incentives) to get broad buy-in. For example, some say combine SC reform with giving something in General Assembly to UfC members (like maybe strengthening GA’s role in peace and security as a consolation). - **Political pressure:** If enough heads of state push (as happened somewhat around 2023 with African Union lobbying, and U.S. showing support), that top-level engagement might break logjams that ambassadors couldn’t. It might take a high-profile meeting or closed-door P5 agreement (“We’ll support X if you support Y”).

Right now, one glimmer is that **global consensus on at least one point Africa needs to be represented** is emerging. If all P5 and major groups truly agree on that, maybe a compromise can cluster around adding 2 African permanents plus some others in a formula that nearly everyone can live with. But someone has to give ground (e.g. Africa on veto, G4 on veto, UfC on permanents at all, P5 on accepting more members).

Finally, an overarching challenge: **time**. The longer reform takes, the more entrenched positions become, but conversely global power balance could shift such that current contenders might wane or new ones emerge, complicating matters more. For instance, will the list of aspirants look the same in 2035? (Maybe Nigeria or others could rise, or conflicts could knock some out, etc.) This uncertainty sometimes makes countries hedge rather than commit now.

To summarize, the reform impasse persists due to: - Rivalries (national and bloc-level). - No consensus model and clashing interests. - The veto of both the P5 (literal) and factions (metaphorical). - Fear of weakening one’s own influence. - Complexity of undertaking such a reform in a divided international climate.

These challenges are not insurmountable, but they require political will, creativity, and compromise which leads into the next section: what possible paths forward could you consider to finally make progress on this long-standing issue?

8. Possible Paths Forward (for you to consider)

Despite the daunting challenges, there are a number of **potentially viable pathways** and creative ideas that you in this committee can explore to break the deadlock. While no solution is perfect, a combination of approaches might pave the way for a more representative and effective Security Council. It’s important that any proposal be **balanced and realistic** meaning it addresses the core demands of major stakeholders without requiring politically impossible concessions. Below are several options and reform packages you might consider, along with their pros and cons:

Option 1: Expand Permanent Seats (Without Veto for New Members) *“New Permanents, Old Vetoes”*

One straightforward path is to **create new permanent member seats** (likely 5-6 of them) as many proposals suggest, but **with the explicit understanding that these new members will not have veto power** (at least initially). This would implement the G4 vision (and partially the African vision) of membership expansion while accommodating P5

red-lines on the veto. For example, the Council could be expanded from 15 to **25 members**, adding: - **6 new permanent seats**: e.g. 2 for Africa, 2 for Asia-Pacific, 1 for Latin America & Caribbean, 1 for Western Europe/Other (likely Germany). - **+4 new non-permanent seats**: one each for Africa, Asia-Pacific, Latin America, Eastern Europe (as per G4 plan)[59].

The new permanent members (say, the G4 plus two African states) would enjoy the prestige of permanence (continuous presence, no need for re-election) and likely greater influence in deliberations, but they **would not possess the veto**. The **P5 would retain their veto** as is.

Pros: This model **significantly improves regional representation**. Africa and Latin America get permanent voices for the first time, Asia gets additional representation through India/Japan, etc. It likely satisfies a majority of UN membership who have supported the idea of new permanents (especially with Africa included). By omitting new vetoes, it **eases P5 acceptance**: indeed, the P5 (US, Russia, China, UK, France) have all signaled they prefer any new permanents not have veto rights[127][104]. It also aligns with the compromise the G4 and others have already agreed to (G4's 2005 draft explicitly said no veto for new permanents pending a review)[33]. For the wider UN, this option addresses the legitimacy deficit (more voices at the table) without making Council decision-making even more difficult by adding more veto-wielders. It's a **realistic near-term compromise** on the vexed veto issue: new members accept a trade-off (prestige without veto) in order to get reform moving.

Cons: The obvious downside is **creating two tiers of permanent members**. New permanents might feel (and be seen as) second-class if they lack the veto. This is a sore point especially for the African Union, which argues new permanent seats *must* come with veto unless veto is abolished for all[66]. Some countries might question whether a permanent seat without veto actually gives them much more power than being a rotating member – after all, without veto they cannot unilaterally block actions. However, they would still have **considerable influence**: their continuous presence means involvement in all decisions, and they could still preside over the Council when their turn comes, chair committees, etc. Another con: the UfC group might still oppose this since it does create new permanents (even without veto). Countries like Italy or Pakistan may maintain that any new permanents are unacceptable. However, some skeptics might be swayed if veto is off the table (their argument against new permanents often cites fear of more vetoes or entrenched power removing veto mitigates that). There is also the risk that new permanents will inevitably push to gain veto in the future but that can be handled by a **review clause** (see Option 3 below) to reassess veto question down the line.

Option 2: Expand Only Non-Permanent Seats (with Creative Variations) “*Elected Seats Boost*”

A more conservative approach, championed by the Uniting for Consensus group, is to **increase the number of non-permanent (elected) seats** without creating any new permanent members. For instance, the Council could expand from 15 to, say, **25 members by adding 10 elected seats**. These could be distributed regionally (e.g. 2 more for Africa, 2 for Asia-Pacific, 2 for Latin America/Caribbean, 1 for Eastern Europe, 2 for WEOG, and maybe 1 floating or for small states). Variations on this option: - **Longer-term elected seats**: Some of the new seats could be for a longer duration than the current 2 years, potentially **3 or 4-year terms with the possibility of immediate re-election**. This concept, akin to Model B of the High-Level Panel[40], creates a category of “semi-permanent” members – countries could hold these seats for extended periods if they continue to get elected. For example, a country like India or Brazil could keep getting re-elected to a 4-year term seat, effectively staying on the Council long-term without formal permanent status. - **Rotational shared seats**: Seats could be designated to regions or sub-regions to rotate among a group of countries. For example, one idea has been a **“Arab swing seat”** alternating between Asian and African Arab states, or a **“small island developing states (SIDS) seat”** rotating among small island nations[58]. This ensures specific constituencies get periodic representation.

Pros: This option is **most palatable to countries opposing new permanent members** (like UfC group). It avoids elevating specific states above others, which can seem more fair to regional rivals. Every new seat is an elected seat, so in principle any country in the region could occupy it over time. This **maintains more accountability** – permanents are answerable only to themselves, elected members have to win votes from peers to serve. It's also simpler legally: no need to name new permanent members in the Charter, just change the number of elected seats in Article 23 and adjust regional allocation. The **veto remains with only P5**, unchanged, so P5 might accept this since it doesn't diminish their power (some P5, like China, actually prefer this model to avoid Japan/India being permanent thorn in their side[107]). It would **immediately give greater voice to underrepresented regions** because adding, say, 2 African elected seats means at any time 5 African countries (3 existing + 2 new) sit on Council, addressing some representational concerns (though not the prestige issue).

Cons: Many countries (especially G4 and Africa) feel this doesn't go far enough. They argue it **does not solve the legitimacy issue** of outdated power distribution – it just makes the Council larger, not necessarily more authoritative or reflective of current power realities. Major aspirants would still not have a permanent voice; they could be elected more often possibly, but not guaranteed. Also, elected seats being 2-year (or even 4-year) terms means rapid turnover – some criticize that the Council benefits from institutional memory and that a permanent presence of key stakeholders is needed for effectiveness. Another drawback: if countries like India or Brazil keep getting re-elected, it's essentially permanent membership via the backdoor but without the formal recognition – some states feel if that's going to happen, better to acknowledge it with a permanent seat. **African Union explicitly rejects** a reform without permanent seats as insufficient (they want permanents for Africa to correct historical injustice). Politically, G4 nations and their supporters would likely vote against a reform that leaves them out of permanent status, making it hard to reach 2/3 GA support. So while easier for P5, this option might fail to garner the broad support among UN members needed for adoption – ironically the opposite problem of Option 1.

However, a subset of this path could be pursued as an **“interim solution”**: For example, if full agreement on permanents can't be reached now, states might agree to first add some non-perm seats immediately (like an “easy win”), with the understanding that talks continue on permanent seats. This could at least improve representation short-term. But there's a risk interim becomes permanent and true reform gets shelved.

Option 3: “Intermediate Model” Semi-Permanent or Region-Based Seats + Review Clause *“Hybrid Compromise”*

Given the divide between Options 1 and 2, a compromise “hybrid” could be considered: - Introduce a **new category of seats**: not fully permanent, but longer-term and possibly renewable. For instance, create **8 seats with 4-year terms, renewable once** (so a country could serve 8 years straight if re-elected), as was in High-Level Panel Model B[40]. These would effectively be semi-permanent seats. They could be allocated regionally (e.g. 2 for Africa, 2 for Asia, 1 Latin, 1 Eastern Europe, 2 WEOG for example). - At the same time, perhaps **add 1-2 true permanent seats** for the most consensual candidates – e.g. one for Africa (Africa chooses a representative) and one for Asia (likely India or Japan, whichever is more acceptable by consensus). This is hypothetical – if consensus can form around at least a couple of new permanents while others get semi-perms, it's a mix. - Crucially, include a **mandatory review conference or sunset clause**: After, say, 15 years, UN members will review how the reform is working and can decide to adjust – possibly converting some semi-permanent seats into permanent or revisiting veto arrangements[33]. This “sunset” or review clause (the G4 proposed one) gives comfort that nothing is set in stone if it's not effective. It could help reluctant states sign on now, knowing they can revisit issues later.

Pros: This approach tries to balance inclusion with flexibility. **Semi-permanent seats** allow major players to be present frequently or continuously if their region supports them, but they also ensure that smaller countries in the region have a chance if they can garner support. It might mollify rivals: for example, if Asia gets two 4-year renewable seats, India and Japan could each occupy one, but since they have to be re-elected after 4 years by GA vote, they have an incentive to be responsive and not take it for granted. Meanwhile, countries like Pakistan or Italy could take comfort that these seats aren't *technically* permanent – if India or Japan lost favor, they could be replaced next cycle. The **review clause** is a big pro: it builds in an opportunity to correct course. If Africa says “we insist on veto for new permanents,” a review 15 years later could allow revisiting that question with experience (perhaps by then P5 might agree to mild veto reform, or new permanents proven themselves to be given veto). For states unsure about permanents, it's easier to agree if they know it's revisitable. This also might overcome P5 resistance – they might accept a trial period of expansion, reserving their right to block further changes later if it doesn't work.

Cons: It's somewhat complex and could be seen as **kicking the can** on key issues. Hardliners on both sides might dislike it: G4 really want the prestige of official permanent seats, and might see 4-year renewable as less than they hoped. UfC countries might still oppose any arrangement that effectively entrenches certain countries (even if semi-permanent). The system of re-election could get politicized (regions might split votes, etc.). And the review conference promise – there's no guarantee that it would successfully lead to more reform; some worry it'd just delay decisions (e.g. in 15 years we might still be gridlocked). However, having a scheduled review at least forces the issue to be reconsidered, which is better than indefinite status quo. Another con: it might be tricky to put in Charter text. But likely you'd amend the Charter to allow a new category of seats (with length specified), and maybe a GA resolution committing to a review (since amending the Charter itself to include a self-expiring provision is unusual, but could be done – Article 109 provides some precedent for mandated review, though that wasn't binding as we saw).

This intermediate approach could serve as a **transitional compromise** acknowledging that full agreement on permanent seats/veto now is not possible, but we can make progress and set a future date to settle remaining issues. You could refine how long terms should be, how re-election works (immediate re-election allowed or not), etc.

Option 4: Veto Reform via Voluntary Restraint or Procedural Mechanisms *“Curbing the Veto’s Excesses”*

Regardless of how membership expansion goes, addressing veto use is critical for many members. A realistic path forward on veto reform is through **political commitments and procedural tweaks**, rather than trying to amend the Charter to remove veto (which P5 won’t accept). Key sub-options: - **Adopt or reinforce a voluntary Code of Conduct:** Push for all P5 (and indeed all Council members) to sign onto the ACT Code of Conduct pledging no veto (or no vote against) on resolutions responding to genocide, crimes against humanity, or war crimes[80]. Already 2 P5 (UK, France) support this and over 100 other states. A resolution in this committee or GA could urge the remaining P5 (USA, Russia, China) to join. While voluntary, if enough pressure mounts (especially from global public opinion and middle powers), perhaps even those holdouts might feel compelled in extreme situations to comply. - **Encourage use of the French/Mexico veto-suspension initiative:** It’s similar to ACT but specifically P5-focused. You could call for operationalizing the French proposal that if e.g. the UN Secretary-General certifies a mass atrocity is occurring, P5 collectively refrain from veto[100]. They could debate criteria and thresholds for this mechanism. Even if not formalized legally, getting all P5 on record to support at least some form of veto restraint in atrocity cases would be a breakthrough. - **Enhance the 2022 GA “veto accountability” mechanism:** Since GA now meets after each veto[88], perhaps this committee could propose ways to make that more impactful e.g. recommending that vetoing P5 **provide a written explanation to the GA** and engage in genuine dialogue at that GA meeting. Or propose that the GA, when meeting after a veto, could adopt a resolution expressing its view (though not legally binding, it builds moral pressure). This would underscore that a veto is not the last word the rest of the world will have its say. - **Consider a GA “Uniting for Peace” approach:** Reaffirm and potentially broaden the *Uniting for Peace* resolution mechanism where the GA can step in when Council is paralyzed by veto. You could encourage that in cases of humanitarian emergencies blocked by veto, the GA should actively convene Emergency Special Sessions and make strong recommendations. This doesn’t change the veto, but it bypasses Council to ensure action/international will is marshaled (as seen recently with GA emergency session on Ukraine after Russia’s veto). - **Promote P5 self-restraint in non-atrocity situations too:** For example, suggest that P5 agree to use veto only when truly necessary for vital national interests. Perhaps even a gentleman’s agreement that on issues not involving direct conflicts of major powers, they won’t veto if there’s overwhelming Council support. (E.g., if 14-1 on a draft, maybe the sole P5 could consider abstaining instead of veto, out of respect for majority this could be mooted as a norm). - **Encourage more inclusion in decision-making to reduce need for veto:** If P5 consulted more with other members and compromised earlier, veto use might diminish. You can push for improved working methods such as: earlier draft sharing, involving elected members in penholding (drafting resolutions), and using informal straw polls before formal votes to gauge support (so vetoes aren’t surprises). These won’t eliminate veto but can make Council outcomes more consensual, reducing veto frequency.

Pros: These measures **do not require Charter change** they can be implemented through political will and GA resolutions (which P5 can’t veto). They directly respond to the criticism that veto has been abused by at least requiring transparency and encouraging restraint. Over time, if norms change such that using a veto to block, say, aid to civilians in war becomes seen as taboo, P5 behavior might adjust similar to how certain weapons (like chemical weapons) became taboo internationally. It’s a pragmatic approach: rather than slaying the beast (veto) which you can’t because it’s chained in Charter you tame it through training and social pressure. Already we see movement: 2022 GA resolution was unprecedented[89]; more than half of P5 (France/UK/US) co-sponsored it, showing P5 sensitivity to perception. This momentum can be built upon.

Cons: It relies on voluntary adherence **not legally binding**. Russia or China can simply ignore a code of conduct if they feel their core interests are at stake (indeed Russia vetoed a draft on Syria chemical weapons even after France’s plea for restraint in atrocity contexts). The voluntary pledge has no enforcement except naming and shaming. And some P5 may simply refuse to join; e.g., to date, neither Russia nor China have shown any inclination to adopt veto restraint pledges, and the US has been ambivalent (though supportive in rhetoric, it hasn’t formally signed ACT Code). Another con: these do not give other countries veto which some reformers, like African Union, argue either all should have or none. But universalizing veto is unrealistic, so focusing on restraint is more practical. Also, these measures don’t satisfy those who want more structural change they don’t give new members more power, just slightly moderate existing P5 power.

Nonetheless, veto restraint is widely seen as a necessary complement to any expansion. You could incorporate it into a broader package: e.g., if new permanent seats are added without veto, simultaneously the existing P5 agree to curb their veto usage to even the playing field a bit.

Option 5: Regional Rotational Permanent Seats *“Collective Permanency”*

Another inventive approach discussed has been to allocate **permanent seats to regions**, which could then rotate the country occupying that seat. This attempts to reconcile the desire for permanent representation of regions with the desire to not permanently anoint one country. For example: - **Africa’s two permanent seats** could be defined as “African Permanent Seat 1 and 2” in the Charter, to be filled by African countries chosen perhaps by the African Union. The AU might rotate who fills it every X years (some proposals say rotate every Council term or every few years among Africa’s sub-regions). This way, Africa is always represented permanently, but not by the same two countries indefinitely theoretically all major African nations could take turns over decades. - Similarly, an **Arab Permanent Seat** could rotate between, say, an Arab country from Asia and one from Africa. - A **Latin American Permanent Seat** could alternate between, for instance, Brazil and another Latin country (like a consensus pick of Latin group). - An idea even floated: a **“Small States Permanent Seat”** a creative notion where a coalition of small countries shares a permanent seat, rotating among themselves (ensuring small nations’ perspective is always present).

Pros: This addresses representational fairness no single country monopolizes a region’s permanent voice. It could reduce rivalry: for instance, if **India and Pakistan** had to share an “Asia seat” (not that they would easily agree), it ensures both get a shot eventually. Or more practically, if **Brazil, Mexico, Argentina** could agree to rotate on a Latin seat, they all have stakes in reform. It might be more sellable to some UfC members: they oppose making a rival permanent, but if they know they might get a turn to occupy that seat, it softens the blow. It also fits with certain regional principles; Africa often emphasizes collective representation a rotating African seat aligns with their spirit of solidarity (though AU currently wants fixed seats). For P5, it doesn’t increase the number of veto players (if any, presumably they’d still not give these rotating seats a veto, or if they did, the veto would attach to whichever country holds it at the time complicated but possible).

Cons: Implementation is complex and unprecedented. The Charter would have to specify something like “the African Union shall designate the Member State to occupy the African permanent seat for each term” which is doable legally, but politically fraught: how would the AU pick? It could lead to intense intra-regional competition every few years. Also, the occupant keeps changing, which might affect continuity. A rotating permanent seat might also weaken accountability which country’s name is on it in SC records? Likely it’d still be the country name, so it’s effectively an elected seat of indefinite continuity for region, which is conceptually weird. Additionally, some aspirants won’t like sharing: India, for example, feels it deserves its own seat, not to rotate with Pakistan or others. Nigeria or South Africa might not be thrilled to rotate with each other; they’d rather have one each. And small states might not actually have capacity to handle permanent seat responsibilities if it rotated to them (e.g., a very small island might not want that burden even if symbolically nice). So far, no region has clearly endorsed this model, except a notion in Africa that if veto isn’t abolished, at least Africa’s two seats should have veto because then veto is “held collectively” but that’s not exactly rotation, just pushing for equal rights.

Option 6: Increase Council’s Accountability and Working Methods (regardless of structural reform) *“Make the Council Work Better”*

Even without drastic changes in membership or veto, many UN members advocate improving how the Council works to enhance inclusivity and transparency. Some measures to consider: - **Mandatory Consultations with Regional Organizations:** E.g., require the Council to consult the African Union on conflicts in Africa, or the Arab League on Middle East issues. This gives regions a say even if they lack permanent seats. - **Expand Arrria-formula meetings / informal briefings with non-members:** So interested states can present views to Council members more often on issues affecting them. - **Better selection process for elected members:** Possibly coordinate within regional groups to ensure that capable, representative countries get elected (some regions already try to balance sub-regions or choose countries active in UN). - **Reform of penholdership:** Currently, P5 (especially France, UK, US) often act as “penholders” drafting resolutions on certain issues. There’s call to rotate penholdership to elected members or involve new perspectives. Sharing this responsibility would empower non-P5 members. - **Strengthen relationship with GA:** For instance, Council could submit more frequent reports to GA, or hold occasional joint debates with GA on thematic issues. Or as some propose, if a Council resolution is vetoed, maybe an automatic referral to GA for discussion (which 76/262 partially does). - **Ensure new voices in subsidiary organs:** If expansion is delayed, one idea is to give influential non-Council states seats in important subsidiary bodies (like sanctions committees or working groups) as observers or participants. For example, including India or Brazil in discussions about issues where they have stakes, even if they aren’t currently on Council, to mitigate their absence.

Pros: These steps can be enacted relatively quickly through Council working methods decisions or GA resolutions urging them. They show responsiveness to criticism and can improve the Council's output and legitimacy *even without Charter changes*. Many of these have broad support (even P5 often say they are open to improving working methods). They also complement structural changes: an expanded Council that also has reformed practices would maximize effectiveness.

Cons: They do not satisfy calls for structural justice (they don't give new seats or remove veto). Some may be seen as cosmetic if larger issues remain unresolved. P5 might quietly resist some (penholder reform, for instance, P5 have resisted because it diminishes their control of drafting). Also, these don't require this committee to solve membership issues – they're more low-hanging fruit. But from a negotiating perspective, including such improvements in a reform package can sweeten the deal for those who might not get everything they want structurally.

In practice, a final solution might be a **package** combining several of the above options. For instance, you might craft a resolution that: - Expands Council membership with a mix of new permanent (sans veto) and additional elected seats (Options 1 + 2 hybrid). - Incorporates a review after 15 years to revisit veto and categories (Option 3). - Strongly endorses veto restraint in atrocity cases (Option 4). - Improves working methods and GA-SC interaction (Option 6).

Such a package tries to address most parties: G4 get permanent seats (if not veto immediately), Africa gets seats (veto maybe later in review), UfC gets more elected seats and possibly the comfort of review, P5 keep veto and gain legitimacy from reform, small states get more avenues to be heard (via working methods changes).

Ultimately, **you should weigh** each idea's feasibility and trade-offs. Reforms need to gather a critical mass of support without triggering a P5 veto at ratification. They should also strive to maintain or improve the Council's ability to act; a reform that paralyzes the Council further would defeat the purpose. By considering these paths, you can mix and match elements to craft a resolution that moves the world closer to a Security Council fit for today's challenges.

9. Guiding Questions for You

To spur critical thinking and negotiation in this committee, consider the following key questions:

- **Representation vs. Efficiency:** *How can the Security Council be made more representative of the UN membership without compromising its ability to act swiftly and effectively?* In other words, what is the **optimal Council size and composition** to balance inclusivity and functionality?
- **Criteria for New Members:** *If new permanent members are to be added, what criteria should be used to select them?* Possibilities include population size, economic contribution, military capacity, regional representation, commitment to UN peacekeeping, etc. Should **specific countries** be named in a reform (e.g. G4 states), or should it be left to regional groups to decide their representatives?
- **Permanent vs. Elected Balance:** *Is it preferable to increase permanent seats, elected seats, or both?* What are the merits of **longer-term elected seats** or **regional rotating seats** as alternatives to permanent seats held by one country indefinitely?
- **The Veto Question:** *Should the veto power be altered, and if so, how?* Are you in favor of **eliminating the veto, restricting its use, or maintaining it as is?** If maintaining it, should any voluntary constraints (like not using veto in mass atrocity situations) be formally recognized? How can the Council address the **"veto paralysis"** in situations where one P5's interests are involved in a conflict (e.g. Russia in Ukraine, US in Israel-Palestine)?
- **Transitional Measures:** *Would you support an interim or phased reform approach?* For example, agreeing on some expansion now (perhaps of non-permanent seats or a limited number of permanent seats) with a **built-in review** in 10-15 years to assess adding more or addressing veto then. Or do you believe an all-in-one comprehensive reform is necessary to avoid losing momentum?
- **Regional Consensus:** *How can regions like Africa, Latin America, and Asia-Pacific achieve consensus on representation?* For instance, can African states agree on which countries fill their proposed permanent seats, or a mechanism to choose them? Can Latin American nations overcome divisions to support one of their own for a permanent seat? How will **Arab states** or **OIC** representation be handled – through an Arab world seat or via Africa/Asia seats?

- **Small States' Voice:** *In an expanded Council, how will the interests of smaller states be protected?* With more big players possibly dominating, what mechanisms (like **rotating sub-regional seats or consultation processes**) can ensure small and medium-sized countries still have influence? Does your delegation support proposals like a dedicated seat for **small island developing states (SIDS)** or others?
- **P5 Buy-In:** *What incentives or assurances can be offered to the current P5 to secure their support (or at least non-opposition) for reform?* How can we address P5 concerns that reform might diminish their influence or overwhelm the Council? Is **not extending veto to new members** enough to placate them? Could reform be tied to other reforms that P5 want (for example, some P5 want changes in UN budget voting or peacekeeping financing)?
- **UN Charter Amendment Strategy:** *If a reform agreement is reached in the General Assembly, how will you ensure it is successfully ratified by the required number of states including all P5?* This is a practical question: do we have a plan for national-level advocacy, especially in P5 capitals, to get parliamentary ratifications? Should the reform come into effect only after all key ratifications (perhaps including some waiting period)?
- **No-Reform Scenario:** *What are the consequences if the Council is not reformed?* How does the legitimacy and authority of the UNSC suffer if membership remains the same in 2030 or 2045? Does the risk of UN marginalization or alternative groupings (like ad-hoc coalitions, regional security bodies) supplanting the Council's role motivate countries to compromise now? Essentially, how urgent is this reform to your country and others, and what are you willing to trade-off to achieve it?
- **Beyond the Council:** *How will Security Council reform impact the broader UN system?* Consider the relationship with the **General Assembly** (will a more representative SC improve GA-SC cooperation?), with **peacekeeping operations** (will contributors be more willing if Council is more inclusive?), and with global trust in multilateralism. Are there complementary reforms (like revitalizing the GA or ECOSOC) that should go hand-in-hand so that UN reform is holistic?

Reflecting on these questions will help you clarify their national positions and priorities. They also highlight the complex interplay of principle and pragmatism in this debate. You are encouraged to think creatively and find common ground remember, our goal is to arrive at a reform model that garners widespread support (ideally at least the magic two-thirds majority and P5 acquiescence). Diplomacy and flexibility will be key. As one envoy quipped, *"Security Council reform is like solving a Rubik's cube blindfolded you have to make moves in trust and sometimes undo a piece to solve the puzzle."* Keeping an open mind and focusing on the collective good of the UN will be vital as you tackle this monumental topic.

10. Annotated Bibliography / Suggested Readings

To further research and deepen understanding of Security Council reform, you should consult the following sources, which provide valuable insights, historical context, and diverse perspectives on the issue:

- **United Nations Charter (1945)** *Especially Articles 23, 27, 108, and 109.* The Charter is the legal foundation for UNSC's structure and the amendment process. Article 23 outlines current Council composition; Article 27 details voting (veto)[68]; Article 108-109 cover how to amend the Charter[52][42]. *Reading the Charter provisions is essential* to understand what legal hurdles reform faces and what exactly would need to change for any proposal to take effect.
- **"In Larger Freedom: Towards Development, Security and Human Rights for All" (Report of the UN Secretary-General, 2005)** This report by Kofi Annan includes a section on Security Council reform, endorsing the High-Level Panel's proposals and urging member states to take action. It is useful for understanding the UN leadership's perspective on why reform is crucial and the options (Models A and B) that were on the table[128][40]. (UN document A/59/2005).
- **High-Level Panel on Threats, Challenges and Change (2004), "A More Secure World: Our Shared Responsibility"** A panel of eminent persons convened by the UN proposed two reform models. Sections 244-260 of the report discuss the Security Council's composition and the rationale for Models A and B[124][40]. This is key to see a somewhat neutral expert approach to balancing different interests. (UN document A/59/565).

- **African Union’s Ezulwini Consensus (2005)** This document (adopted by the AU Executive Council) lays out Africa’s common position on UN reform. It explicitly calls for “no less than two permanent seats for Africa with all privileges including the right of veto”[34], as well as five non-permanent seats for Africa. Reading Ezulwini (and the related Sirte Declaration) is vital to grasp the principled stance of African states. (Available via AU documents and also summarized in CSIS analysis below.)
- **G4 Ministerial Joint Statement on UNSC Reform (25 September 2025)** A recent statement by the foreign ministers of India, Brazil, Germany, and Japan, reaffirming their joint push for reform. It highlights current justifications (geopolitical shifts, conflicts demanding effective UN response) and their support for African representation[29][65]. This statement gives a contemporary snapshot of the G4’s arguments and sense of urgency. (Press release by Government of India [108][65].)
- **Security Council Report, “In Hindsight: Security Council Reform” (September 2019)** *Security Council Report* is an independent think tank. This particular analysis (Sept 2019 Monthly Forecast) reviews the history of reform efforts, main sticking points, and the status of negotiations as of 2019. It’s useful for understanding the five key issues identified in the IGN process and where consensus or lack thereof existed[31]. (Available on [SecurityCouncilReport.org](https://www.securitycouncilreport.org).)
- **Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), “Africa’s Design for a Reformed UN Security Council” (Ovigwe Eguegu et al., October 1, 2024)** This commentary[129][54] explains African nations’ perspective on UNSC reform, why it matters to Africa (e.g. 70% of Council agenda is African issues[24]), and recent developments like increased P5 acknowledgment of Africa’s demands[118][130]. It also discusses opposition arguments and alternative ideas (like abolition of veto, etc.)[131][39]. An accessible piece to understand the African bloc and global south momentum.
- **Council on Foreign Relations (CFR), “The UN Security Council” Backgrounder (Updated August 2025)** A thorough explainer on how the Council works and reform debates. Especially see sections on *calls for reform* and *prospects for reform*, which mention the main proposals and recent positions of key countries[27][45]. It notes the U.S. position (Biden’s support for expansion)[45] and the general stalemate. Good for a balanced overview. (CFR.org backgrounder by CFR editors[28][75].)
- **Gonzaga Journal of International Law, “Reforming the UN Security Council” (Fall 2021, by Ciara Finlay)** An academic article examining reform proposals and P5 attitudes. It provides insight into *why P5 are wary*, e.g. the U.S., China, Russia reluctant to share veto[127][132], and compares proposals (G4 vs UfC vs African)[133][101]. It’s useful for understanding P5 perspectives and possible compromises like a “hybrid model” the author suggests. (See excerpt in our sources[127][132].)
- **International Peace Institute (IPI), “UN Security Council Reform: Perspectives and Prospects” (various authors)** IPI has published policy papers on the politics of UNSC reform, often including viewpoints from diplomats involved in negotiations. These can provide candid insight into the mood of the negotiations, such as why 2005 failed or how smaller states view the issue.
- **General Assembly Resolution 76/262 (26 April 2022)** This GA resolution created the veto accountability mechanism[89][88]. Reading its content and the debate around it (press releases like “General Assembly Adopts Landmark Resolution on Veto Use”) will show how frustration with veto led to action. It’s a concrete example of the GA asserting itself.

Each of these readings will deepen your understanding of different facets: the legal framework, historical attempts, positions of key players, and emerging ideas. They are recommended for you to craft well-informed, solution-oriented contributions to the debate on **“Reforming the UNSC: Emphasizing Membership Expansion and Restricting Veto Power.”**

[1] [2] [4] [6] [7] United Nations Security Council - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/United_Nations_Security_Council

[3] [8] [27] [28] [45] [75] [78] [91] The UN Security Council | Council on Foreign Relations

<https://www.cfr.org/background/un-security-council>

[5] [12] [13] [16] What is the Security Council? | Security Council

<https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/what-security-council>

[9] [69] [70] [82] [83] [84] [86] [100] [103] Why France wishes to regulate use of the veto in the United Nations Security Council - Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs

<https://www.diplomatie.gouv.fr/en/french-foreign-policy/france-and-the-united-nations/france-and-the-united-nations/france-and-the-united-nations-security-council/why-france-wishes-to-regulate-use-of-the-veto-in-the-united-nations-security-65315/>

[10] [11] [14] [15] [67] [68] [97] [98] [99] United Nations Security Council veto power - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/United_Nations_Security_Council_veto_power

[17] [18] [21] [26] [31] [37] [46] [47] [72] [105] [121] Reform of the United Nations Security Council - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Reform_of_the_United_Nations_Security_Council

[19] [20] [22] [25] [32] [33] [42] [43] [48] [52] [53] [59] [60] [66] [79] [95] [111] [112] [113] [114] Reform of the United Nations Security Council questions and answers - Federal Foreign Office

<https://www.auswaertiges-amt.de/en/aussenpolitik/internationale-organisationen/vereintenationen/reformsr-fragen-231618>

[23] [24] [30] [34] [35] [36] [38] [39] [44] [50] [51] [54] [55] [56] [57] [63] [64] [92] [96] [102] [104] [118] [119] [125] [129] [130] [131] Africa's Design for a Reformed UN Security Council

<https://www.csis.org/analysis/africas-design-reformed-un-security-council>

[29] [65] [108] [109] [110] [115] [116] [117] G4 reaffirms strong support for Common African Position, permanent membership in UNSC - Times of Oman

<https://timesofoman.com/article/163248-g4-reaffirms-strong-support-for-common-african-position-permanent-membership-in-uns>

[40] [124] [126] [128] Summary of

<https://archive.globalpolicy.org/reform/initiatives/panels/high/1201panelsumm.htm>

[41] General Assembly Hears Renewed Appeals for Substantive Security...

<https://press.un.org/en/2022/ga12472.doc.htm>

[49] [62] [93] [94] [101] [106] [107] [127] [132] [133] gjil.scholasticahq.com

<https://gjil.scholasticahq.com/article/40362.pdf>

[58] Regulation of Force and Coercion - Better Order Project

<https://betterorderproject.org/regulation-of-force-and-coercion/>

[61] [PDF] Press Release OIC calls for adequate representation of Muslim...

https://pakun.org/uploads/05202024-01_press-releases.pdf

[71] [73] [74] [76] [77] [80] [81] [85] [88] [89] [90] [120] Called to Account? The Permanent Five and the Veto | IIEA

<https://www.iiea.com/blog/called-to-account-the-permanent-five-and-the-veto>

[87] General Assembly Debate on Security Council Veto of Resolution...

<https://press.un.org/en/2025/ga12717.doc.htm>

[122] Question of equitable representation on and increase in the...

<https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/177987>

[123] In Hindsight: Security Council Reform, September 2019 Monthly...

<https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/monthly-forecast/2019-09/in-hindsight-security-council-reform.php>

Copyright Syed